

KT MORRISON

Six Weeks in Winter

BOOK 2: SNOWBURST



SNOWBURST

SIX WEEKS IN WINTER

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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SNOWBURST

A **Six Weeks In Winter** book

32,500 words

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Written by KT Morrison

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BETWEEN CLASSES

Up since dawn, Janie had eaten breakfast, drank a pot of tea, did the chores out in the chicken house, cleaned the kitchen, made John a lunch in case he was going back to work today. Anything but go into the addition and see her painting and Maceo's, and have a full and vivid reminder of the awful thing that transpired last night. She'd folded laundry, brought in firewood, drank another pot of tea and avoided the pantry. What would she say when she saw him today?

It was awful waking up in John's arms this morning. At first it was warm and happy; being held by her grizzly bear of a husband always made her feel good (except of course when she had done something so awful, so unkind, so dirty...) She didn't even deserve to wake up content like that. Instead, she punished herself with chores.

But it was almost nine in the morning now and soon the two men in her house would be up and awake. Maceo first; John didn't come home to bed till late this morning, her man plowing all night long. What are you going to say when you see Maceo today, Janie? She should tell him he can't stay here. But then where would he go? Maceo was staying here for five more weeks. And what of Evan? Her son was staying with Maceo's family. What was she going to do, go to the Home Exchange people, tell them she changed her mind? *Like they wouldn't ask you why, woman.* What would she tell them?—not the truth, that was for sure. *Would you blame Maceo, maybe tell them you didn't feel safe or something?* She would never do something like that that might harm the young man. It wasn't her that didn't feel safe with him in her home; it was her sanity, her peace of mind, but most of all it was her marriage and the love and respect of her husband that

wasn't safe. Truly, though—and she loathed to consider it—the idea of sending Maceo away, of no longer having him in her life, was devastating. They would just have to change the way they interacted, they would have to make amends, she would forgive him, and they would move on.

And what of John?

There was movement now upstairs as she came in from the porch after spreading salt on an icy patch below the side steps leading to the pens. Footsteps near the top of the stairs that put a ball of dread in her stomach as she removed her farm coat and hung it on its hook above the bench in the mudroom. An old vanity mirror hung there on a wire and she checked her reflection. No bags under the eyes, which was good because her sleep hadn't been the deepest or most nourishing. She'd been plagued by awful memories of the night before. She popped the collar on her flannel shirt, opened the neck a little till it sat right, smoothed her hair back—this new cut really held its flattering shape. No makeup, but the beeswax balm she used to protect her lips from the nip of winter put a mild gloss on them.

In the kitchen, she made herself busy, spritzed it with cleaner and wiped it down though it didn't need it, and set the kettle to boil for her third pot of tea; the whole time listening for more sounds from upstairs. When she heard the steps creaking, someone on the way down, she smoothed her hair again and resumed wiping the counter so she would look busy. Her heart was hammering.

Heavy weight came around the landing, descended the last of the staircase, hidden by her stove and the chimney, and she prepared herself for what she would say. The cloth was scrubbed vigorously over the lip of the sink as Maceo's presence grew closer and her anxiety threatened to boil over. Only it wasn't Maceo...

Around the chimney, John strode, smiling, hands in the pockets of his old bathrobe. He still wore sweatpants and his bare feet were in his slide-on slippers. She was taken aback—she'd anticipated seeing Maceo—she made to say something, but no words came out.

“Good morning, Janie,” he said, in a smooth sort of way—a *knowing* way, and for a fraction of a heartbeat she'd trembled at the thought he somehow knew what she'd done.

She said, “What are you doing up?”

He came around the counter and kissed her cheek, his beard bristling her neck. “I was looking forward to waking up with you...”

She kissed his cheek now, said, “I went to bed early last night. When did you get in?”

“Six,” he said, leaning his butt on the edge of the counter, regarding her. “You didn’t eat dinner last night?”

“No,” she said, shaking her head.

“Weren’t hungry?”

“What?”

“Last night, you weren’t hungry? Or did you and Maceo get caught up in painting?”

“Yeah, we were painting.”

“I saw,” he said. “Really amazing, Janie.”

“My painting? You think so?”

“Yeah, I saw it when I came in. It’s different, but it’s you. Maceo’s teaching you something.”

“He is. Hey, can I make you coffee...?”

“Nah, I’m going to go back to bed...”

“Yeah, you didn’t get any sleep, not even three hours...”

“Why don’t you come back to bed with me?”

“I’m not even tired, John—I’ve been up for hours.”

“Come lay with me.”

“While you sleep?”

He shrugged his shoulders, still smirking. “I got home at six, came into bed with you, and you snuggled up to me. It was nice.”

Now she slumped, smiled back at him sweetly, seeing the warmth in his eyes. She stepped across to his side of the kitchen and patted his chest with both hands. He hugged her, and she kissed his lips. There was something underneath his robe...



Now she found it. With his eyes on hers, her light body held in his arms, he watched her frown, then push away from him. He made a sucking sound from one side of his cheek and winked. “Come upstairs with me, Janie.”

“It’s nine in the morning, John,” she said, but he could see he’d got her smiling.

“It’s the middle of the night for me, Janie,” he said, opening his robe. His erection poked out the front of his sweatpants in a heather gray sail. It felt like glorious iron.

She laughed a little and touched her cheek. Color bloomed and her mouth spread in a glossy smile.

“What do you say, Janie? Let’s go up and roll around in bed.”

“Where did this come from?” she said, her hand coming down to rub the cotton underside of his prominent bulge.

“Ordered it online, Janie, just for you. Now, come on,” he said as he took her hands, “come back to bed.”

“It’s so bright out,” she said, that smile still spread on her. “What if, you know... he,” she motioned upstairs with her head, “gets up?”

“You think he’ll come into our bedroom?”

She made a strange face—a quick look of worry—but then her smile returned. “Are you going to go back to work?”

“Yeah. Later. Maintenance. More snow coming overnight.”

The troubled faced returned.

“Sorry, Janie, it...”

“I know—”

“If you don’t want to, I’m not going to make you...”

“John, don’t be like that, it’s not—”

There was a ding on the counter behind him, the sound of Janie’s phone receiving a text. Janie hugged herself against him, pressing her stomach against his hardness, reading her phone. He asked her who it was.

“Marissa. She’s bringing some friends. Says she wants to do laundry.”

“When?”

“They’re on their way.”

“That’ll be nice,” he said, wrapping his arms around her.

“John?”

“Yeah?”

“I’ll go upstairs with you.”

He squeezed her tighter as excitement raced through him again. “You will?”

“Yeah,” she said, and looked up to show him a smile. “We can’t be long.”

“Yeah, yeah,” he said, heaving off the counter and taking her by the hand; Janie trotted behind, giggling.

When he came around the chimney toward the steps, he stopped with her. The pantry door was ajar. His heart raced, his erection throbbed. He pivoted left, brought her to the pantry, Janie protesting behind him, asking him what on earth he was doing.

“Get in here with me,” he growled, backed in and pulled her along. She looked horrified.

“John, what are you doing!”

Both of them inside, he closed the door and flicked on the overhead fluorescents. “You don’t want to be long? You don’t want to go upstairs...”

“What are you saying?” Her lips trembled.

“Remember after chemistry...? The supply closet on the third floor by the stairwell on the south side...”

Her mouth worked around, her face pinched as she tried to understand him.

“At high school, Janie, get with it...”

“What...? Yeah...?” She looked bewildered.

He held her upper arms and backed her against the shelving, collected those pouting, unsure lips with his and kissed her passionately. His body pressed against hers, his hardness grinding into her stomach. Janie was stiff and awkward, but soon she warmed to him and her body went soft and suppliant underneath him. She lifted one leg and stroked his hip with the inside of her thigh.

Around their kisses, he said, “We used to duck in there...”

“A few times,” she said.

“We were bad...”

“We never had sex in there, John...”

“You used your hand on me...” he said, then got bold and put his hand down the front of her jeans. “And I used my hand on you...” Her jeans were tight and his hand and wrist thick, and they jammed before he could touch between her legs.

She sighed his name and her hands went stroking over his sides. In high school he’d been an athlete, and she used to love touching his body—years had passed and he wished they were seventeen again, and that the feel today under her hands was as good to her as they felt on him. “We can’t do it in here, John,” she gasped, caressing him but giving that look of fright again as her gaze cast around where they stood.

“That’s why we’re doing it here,” he said, and undid the button of her jeans. “You know how bad I wanted to do you back then?”

She gave a shaky, breathy laugh, and her hands came up to cup his beard. “I wanted you to fuck me so bad.”

“Now’s your chance.”

She looked in his eyes and he saw excitement there, but there was still fear, too, or reluctance. With his thumbs, he pushed her jeans down to the top of her thighs, kept their gaze connected. He tried to keep a straight and confident face, but as his hand slipped down the front of her panties and he felt the scratch of her pubic hair between his fingers, his own breath began to tremble.

“What’s happening with you, John?” she whispered.

“I love you, Janie,” he said.

“I love you, too,” she said, and it was almost just like they were back at Wheatville-Chili High—a sweet fantasy, because there was an ocean of togetherness between them; he was heavier, hairier, they had kids, a business, a homestead, he had his tubes snipped (but that meant he could do what he’d wanted back then).

“Come here,” he said, slipping his hand out from her panties and leading her to the chest freezer. “Put your elbows on this table,” he said (the table that had been in the second floor supply room). Janie got it, following him breathlessly, half smiling, half biting her lower lip—*God, that face, he’d ached for that face.*

Janie was compliant, and he was stunned—not just at her, but his own boldness. She stood with her thighs against the freezer’s front face, watching him over her shoulder. He caressed her bare ass, an ass that was fuller and wider than seventeen-year-old Janie, but gorgeous to any man, not just her long-loving husband.

“We have to hurry,” she whispered, “I’ve got Calculus next, and I saw Mr. Walker prowling the hall...”

“Oh, Janie,” he laughed, disbelieving how well this was going. She needn’t fear because this wasn’t going to last long, but he shouldn’t tell her that. Sweatpants pushed down above his knees, he took the tip of his aching erection, his long-lost friend, and reeled at the hot, sopping feel of his wife. A few teasing swipes were all he could stand before he pushed himself fully inside her. Janie moaned and fell over the freezer and he curled over top of her, putting his hands on her narrow waist while his chest pressed her back.

“Oh, God, oh, wow,” Janie, he sighed, grimacing, worrying now if this might be over sooner than he thought. Her insides clung to him with fiery damp, and he didn’t think he could get harder but it was happening.

“You’re so hard, John,” she whispered, “oh, do it... Do it...”

It took concentration, his face was pinched closed behind her back, and he held her too tight as he stroked himself in and out of her.

“John, ah, oh, what’s going on with you...?” She laughed and gasped and moaned as he pulled out and pushed back in.

A great diversion; he slowed. “Ah, mm, your hair...”

“My haircut?”

“Yeah,” he grunted, worked himself in and out in small increments, his scrotum tightening as his testicles threatened to spill over already.

“I should have tipped her more, ah...” She arched her back. It’d been a long time since their intimacy had been like this; years.

He hadn’t wanted to admit it, but the feel of being inside her was thrilling his heart right now and if they were to move too much, it would be over. He got closer to her ear, pinned her against the freezer and groaned an awful admission as he slid deeper inside her: “It’s not just the hair... It’s because you did it...”

She clutched a hand over his where he gripped her waist and caressed him. “Was I letting myself go?”

“No, Janie. Something is happening to you, too, not just me.”

“What do you think is happening?”

“Maceo is putting a charge in you and—”

“No, he’s not...”

“He’s got you charged up, Janie...”

“Bull shit, John, he’s—”

“I love it, Janie, I love seeing you like this...”

“Like what...?”

“He’s got your motor running and I can’t imagine anything in my life better than that...”

“That’s nonsense...”

Shit, he was blowing it. She wasn’t into it. He knew he shouldn’t have brought this up. “It’s just your haircut, Janie, forget about it,” he whispered, gripped her tight and began rolling his hips against her bottom. Her hand squeezed his hard, and he got her grunting with his penetration. “You want me to hurry?”

She didn't answer, only squirmed underneath him. His stomach tightened, his cock swelled larger, harder, as he burst with months of pent-up sex. "Oh, Janie, oh, Janie," he babbled as he launched his semen inside her, hips bucking and zipping tickles blitzing the tip of his penis. Janie sighed and moaned, then relaxed underneath him.

COMMISSION

Sex was the last thing she thought she would be doing this morning, but being with John had restorative properties. Intimacy with her husband was like the wonderful weight of an anchor holding her safe while the waves of lust tried to lure her out to dangerous waters.

“Wow, John, that was unexpected,” she sighed.

“I’ve been plotting it for hours,” he groaned.

“You’re heavy,” she reminded him, swaying her hips and liking the feel between her legs as his stiffness pried at her opening.

He heaved his chest off her, hands spread out on the freezer’s top on either side of her, but stayed with his erection imbedded, hips against her bottom. With slick ease he withdrew his cock from her and she felt a flood come with it. “Ah, shoot,” she said, “paper towels, please, John.”

He shuffled around behind her and she heard him reach a top shelf and bring down a new roll from their supply. She stood slowly, feeling a pull in her hamstrings and John plopped the roll on the freezer in front of her. She tore off two sheets and turned around. Her husband leaned back against the shelving, robe open, pants down his thighs and his familiar erection pointing at her, glistening with wet. With the towel, she dabbed at his semen that had spilled into the seat of her pulled-down panties. John pulled his pants up, his hardness still pushing them out.

It had been a long while since they’d last made love and the way he’d entered her hurt in a high, tearing way, and the paper pressed between her legs soothed some of the sting with pressure. Maceo swelled up in her thoughts, unwelcome, and she considered the size of his penis and what that would have done to her if she’d been even weaker than she was. She

grimaced and shut her eyes to the image—what was she even thinking, the guy was twenty and huge and he would have hurt her and ruined her marriage? Did Maceo even care about her? Care about John?

“Oh, wow,” John laughed and ran his hand through his hair. He was showing the shine of effort and happiness on his face, and it made her uncomfortable knowing how she betrayed him last night.

“That was, wow, great,” he said with a laugh, smiling through his beard. It was good to see him this way.

“It was great, John,” she said, smiled back. Then she swallowed, cleared her throat, and ventured: “I’m glad I got my hair done.”

He groaned and shook his head as though he were embarrassed. She’d rather just drop it, but part of her was worried and fearful about what she’d given away. He chuckled, looked away, said, “It’s a great cut, Janie.”

She watched him a long moment. He closed his robe and tied it. “You said he’s got me charged up. What does that mean?”

“I’m sorry, Janie. It’s all in my head.”

“What’s in your head?”

“I don’t know,” he said, and shoved his big hands in the pockets of his robe.

“Tell me what you’re thinking.”

“You said it was nonsense.”

“Tell me what you think is happening.”

“Look, Janie,” he laughed, scratched at his beard, “I don’t know if you’ve noticed it or not, but our houseguest is a good-looking young man.”

“John, what are you trying to say?”

“Relax, I don’t mean it bad or anything. I mean it positive.”

She met his gaze and this time he didn’t look away. She frowned like she scolded him, but inside she was breaking up. *Was it obvious?* “What’s positive?”

“Janie, I’m not implying anything...”

“Just tell me then.”

“Since he got here you’ve been happier—not like you were unhappy before, I just mean, I don’t know, cheery.”

“Cheery?”

“In your eyes. I see it, Janie. I’m not mad. I’m happy for you. Maceo’s tall, very tall, dark and handsome, and he’s everything you would like in a

guy. With the art? God, if you were hanging out with him and we were all twenty, I would be dying...”

“Nothing’s happening, John,” she said, a certain pleading she’d tried to hide from her voice breaking through anyway.

“I know, Janie, I swear I’m not saying that. And I don’t want you to think I’m condescending—like, look at cute Janie with a crush on Maceo.”

“I don’t have a crush.”

“I’m not attacking you. I’m telling you I’m happy, can’t you hear me? See, if we had a houseguest who was a twenty-year-old girl, and she was way into snowplows and football, you know, my stuff, and she paid attention to me and I was driving her around and eating dinner with her... And she was really sweet and nice to me? I think I’d have a lightness to my step, you know? You’re human.”

She rolled her eyes, scoffed, turned the towel over and pressed the other side against her sex. “Now that’s a fantasy girl. Snowplows and football?”

“And nice to me. I mean, what are the chances?”

“She’d have you going out to get a haircut?”

“Trim my beard even, maybe.”

She groaned, felt her insides collapse like a landslide in a funnel. “I’m so foolish, John. I hate my stupid hair now.”

He was hugging her in an instant. “Janie, no, no way. Hey, you’re so beautiful.”

“You think I’m just trying to look good for Maceo,” she said into the fuzz of his robe.

“No way, Janie, I’m not saying that. Maceo makes you feel good, and it shows. It’s beautiful.”

“I’m so self-conscious now.”

“You know you’re beautiful, stop it. You look like you’re in your twenties, and your body is so incredible. You’re picturing how silly I’d look chasing after a twenty-year-old girl. You don’t look foolish at all. I guarantee Maceo’s been giving you looks.”

John didn’t even know. She left the paper between her legs and put both arms around him. Her sweet husband, good man and provider, divulging something honest and surprising. And she was already a step ahead of him.

Something about his honesty was luring her—coaxing her darkness to feel the warmth of sunlight. The words, the truth, almost came out, but she choked them back. If she knew he wouldn’t be hurt, she could just say

something happened; maybe even leave it at that; assure him they didn't have sex. But didn't they kind of? Both of them naked, man over woman, both aroused, manipulating each other, hips humping; they both orgasmed. She whispered, "Maybe he has, John," happy with the honesty, but wishing she hadn't said it.

"Has he?"

"Maybe," she said, her cheek on his chest, head turned to the side, eyes down to the exact spot where it happened, where she'd cheated with another man in a small measure.

He made a groaning sigh and caressed her back. It was warm and loving and she could feel her eyes swell.

"I like it, Janie," he said, over top of her head. "It's put the light in your eyes that I love. I'm looking at you and you're my Jane that I've known forever, but in your eyes I'm seeing you like when we were young and crazy in love. He's doing things to you I can't, but I love to watch. I'm not jealous—no, wait a minute, I *am* jealous, I'm *really* jealous—but I love the effect he's having on you."

"Okay," she said softly, bewildered and not knowing what else to say. Maceo stirred something inside her and she was crazy to deny it. She thought it had been art, her painting. The events last night showed it was far more.

Now John said, "You know that picture he painted of you? Over the bed? I look at that and... it's what made me hard this morning."

"Why?" she laughed.

"You're beautiful, Janie, and Maceo captured it. This painting is amazing, like, he caught that look in your eye I'm talking about. But it was this big, good-looking kid that saw it. If he can capture it like that by hand—oh, God, I'm terrible at this art stuff, Janie, help me out here..."

"What do you think he sees?"

"This is going to sound crazy, maybe it's just my interpretation because how I see it and how I feel about you—but if he can see it, if Maceo can see it, he must want it, you know? How could you see that and not want it if you're a man?"

"You think he wants me?" She pulled her lower lip under her teeth and clamped it.

“Not in a bad way, Janie.”



The whole thing made him feel foolish, and he hadn't even broached the idea that got him out of bed and searching for her in the first place. But it did feel better than keeping it bottled up, even if he worried she thought he was kinky or weird or something. One thing was certain: the hardness hadn't left him, and he was grateful for that. There was something powerful and masculine and proud about pressing his erection against her—and he knew she would feel it, right through his robe.

Janie wasn't exactly stiff in his arms but he could feel she wanted to pull back. He let her.

When she looked up at him, she said, “You like it if he looks at me?”

He just smiled, embarrassed. “Is that bad? It makes me feel good. He's a handsome guy, don't you like it when he looks at you?”

“John...”

“It must make you feel good.”

“I guess,” she said in a light laugh.

He held her upright, away from the freezer, in a comfortable pose like a slow dance, with his hands resting over the top of her ass, the felt of her flannel on his palms, and those taut bare cheeks under his fingers. *Just go for it.* “I love my painting,” he said.

“It's nice. I'm glad.”

“Do you think he'd do another one?”

“Maybe.”

“Would you sit for him?”

“Pose?”

“Yeah, but you know...”

“What?”

“Maybe, I don't know, make it more, what do you call it?—artistic.”

“What do you mean?” She tried to pull her head back to look at him, but he clutched her tighter because if she looked in his eyes he would lose his nerve.

He said, “Artistic. Uh, revealing...”

“Naked, John?—no way, I can’t do that,” she said and pushed away from him.

“Not naked, Janie,” he said, pursuing her while she regarded him with shock. “Not naked...”

“Revealing?” she said with a scowl.

“No, forget it, I’m sorry...”

She softened in his grip and he heard her give a gentle sigh. “I’m sorry, John, *I’m* sorry,” she whispered.

“I like the painting I have so much,” he told her, “I was laying in bed thinking about what if there was more. Like, I could have a painting of you in our bedroom with, I don’t know, maybe you’re showing us a little something, but it’s tasteful. I could look at it every day—I just... I would like that, and it was exciting...”

“Whoa, John,” she exhaled and put her cheek on his chest again. “That’s why you came here like this?” She humped her hips against his hardness.

“Does that freak you out?”

“No,” she laughed, and groaned. “That’s why I love you.”

“It’s crazy, though, I know. Forget I asked, I’ve been up all night, I don’t know what’s wrong with me.”

“There’s nothing wrong with you, John, that’s a really sweet thing you want.”

“It’s supposed to be hot.”

“It is hot. It’s hot. I just can’t picture me...”

“You don’t have to—”

“I’m not saying no.”

“Really? Oh, wow, I don’t even...”

“I’m not saying yes, either. I don’t even... I can’t picture... He would see me like that?”

“What would you show?”

“John... I... What do you want me to show?”

Oh, God. He groaned, anxious tightness hunching him forward. “A breast. One breast.”

She didn’t laugh. Barely moved at all. “Pose like that?”

He nodded, smoothed his hands around her rump.

“He would see my breast?”

“That’s okay,” he said and grabbed her cheek with each hand and lifted her a little.

“That’s bad, John,” she said, wiggled out of his grip and moved back so they could look at each other. Her eyes stayed on his and he felt less guilty, less embarrassed, because he saw she wasn’t offended. Her mouth worked around, not smiling, her lips tight. She said, “Do you like that?”

Her voice was compelling him, like she wanted to hear him affirm it. He nodded.

Janie watched him, puzzled, mouth opening like she would say something then closing again. His heart beat steadily in his chest as the strangeness of the moment crackled around them. At last, her eyes still on his, her hands came together and let go the loose knot of his bathrobe and it fell open. His cock was just as hard as when he’d come down here and it poked a knot out front of the sweatpants. Janie ran two fingers around the waistband and pulled the pants away and lowered them till the band went across his balls and his erection stuck out proudly to meet her.

Eyes back on his, she raised a palm, licked it, closed her grip around his shaft and began to steadily pump him. He rocked and swayed, gasped. She said, “I love you, John.”

“I love you, Janie,” he said.

“This is really like the supply closet now.”

“Oh, mm,” he groaned and rocked, held his hands on her waist and looked in her eyes.

“How do you picture it, John? Where am I?”

Her tone and demeanor were serious, as though she were asking him an important question. But her badness had bewildered him, and all he could think of was where in the old high school. “What?” he asked.

“If I’m posing for him.”

“Oh, geez, Janie,” he said, rocking forward on his toes; his cock was like an iron bar. “In the... In the studio...”

“How am I posing?” Again, a serious question, not sensual talk. Her strong slick grip pumped on him, her first knuckle bumping the underside of his belly because his erection pointed almost straight upward.

“Maybe, ah, standing, ah, by the window, like, satin over one shoulder...”

“In the sunlight?”

“Yeah...”

“And I’m showing a bare breast?”

He couldn’t even answer, only exhaled shakily.

“And Maceo’s with me?”

“He’s, mm, painting you...”

“There in the room and I’ve only got a satin sheet on...?”

“Yeah, oh, God, yeah...”

“What if I let it drop, what if it falls and I let him paint me—”

He began bucking and his innards clamped down, he hitched breath so hard his lungs felt like they’d lurched up underneath his collarbone. Janie pumped faster and faster, reached between her legs and brought out the dampened paper towel so he could ejaculate into it.

“Oh God, oh no,” he grumbled as he came in her hand, falling forward and clutching the sleeves of her shirt so he wouldn’t knock her back against the freezer. Stream after stream launched from him in quick squirts and he grunted and choked and felt his eyes bulging out of his head. Janie watched him, chewing her lip, doing her best to collect his semen, but it felt like there was a lot. His legs took on a shaking he couldn’t stop.

When it was done, she left him panting. Her thumb kept caressing him and he had to tell her not to do that. She watched him while he recovered, a gentle hold on his throbbing manhood, a paper towel in her other hand. He’d almost stayed in bed. When he’d woken, he looked at that painting on the mantle and thought he might masturbate. In the end, he decided to venture down here and see what he could get going. What happened was more than he could’ve hoped for.

She said, “I have to get another paper towel, okay?”

“Yeah.”

She let him go, set the used towel on the freezer top and tore off more fresh sheets and dried her hands. He stood there still breathing, looking at her narrow flannel back, her blonde, silky hair, and a small sliver of ass cheek below the shirttail and above her Levi’s.

“I almost didn’t come down,” he said.

She didn’t answer, tore off more sheets for him and returned to clean. He let her and watched her work.

“It’s just a fantasy, Janie,” he whispered over her hair.

She nodded, tossed the used sheets to the freezer top with the rest. “I know,” she said, “but I’ll think about it.”

BLAME

With John back in bed getting the sleep he needed, she spent about fifteen minutes folding more laundry, emptying the dryer, and getting the room clear and ready for Marissa when she showed up. She thought about the things John said, alternately teasing at the idea and then extinguishing it. No, when she spoke to Maceo today, she would put him right and put him in his place. She would not make it worse.

The most tragic thought was that she'd been obvious without realizing it. John picked up on it and she was lucky he wasn't angry but instead pleased seeing her (what he called) *revived*. It put her terrifying relationship with Maceo in perspective and she would address Maceo about that. She was no one's fool, no one's toy.

Now she was horsing an overflowing hamper of folded laundry out of the mudroom and plopping it on the kitchen floor beside the wood cookstove. There was a familiar click at the top of the stairs that was Evan's door—this time she was sure the man coming down would be Maceo and not her husband. And unlike earlier, she didn't run off and check her hair and adjust her shirt, instead she stood and waited for him. Her shirt was rumpled and her panties soiled by the seed of her husband. The way it should be.

She watched him come down; his bare tanned legs, his shorts, turning then on the landing and descending the rest of the way. He didn't smile—that would be arrogant—but she noted that he showed no uncertainty or guilt. It didn't make her angry, but she was bothered by it; his expression proved what she believed.

“Good morning,” he said, pausing at the bottom of the staircase before stepping down.

“Good morning, Maceo,” she said.

“You are okay?”

“Fine. Come on down. Come to the kitchen.”

He stepped down, passed by very near to touching, towering over her and glancing down. She didn’t look up. Maceo went to the kitchen and between the island and counter. He poured himself a cup of coffee and she stood behind him with her arms folded. He took it black so turned and sipped, regarded her.

“What do you think we should do now?” she asked with a matronly tone—a schoolteacher holding a student late after class.

He smiled, took another sip, then set the cup on the counter behind him. “Paint,” he said, but still leaning on the counter with both big hands curled over the lip. “I think we were getting somewhere last night.”

“Wow, that’s bold,” she said.

He shrugged, and a smirk flashed on his face. He said, “I hope you and I are the same.”

“Not the same, Maceo, no. I considered calling Home Exchange and ending this visit, but I’m not going to do that, I—”

“Janie, don’t overreact, I—”

“Overreact, Maceo? You seduced me.”

“Seduced you?” His brow lowered like he was puzzled.

“Seduced me, Maceo. And I don’t think it’s funny.” Her volume was beginning to rise, and she moved a little closer so she could lower her voice and be heard. In a firm whisper, she said, “All that stuff, all that feel me nonsense, put my hands on you, see the light, sure, it worked last night, and I know you run that on every pie-eyed art student in Rome, but I’m a grown woman. A married woman. What you did is very disrespectful. I opened my home to you and you’re playing games with me.”

His expression of calm didn’t falter. He said, “You are an adult woman, yes, Janie, you don’t think it’s you who seduce me?”

“You’re doing it again, Maceo. You know I’m not seducing you. Stop it.”

“No, not the way you accuse me. But, what? You think I’m lying, a liar?”

“I think you’re a handsome young man who probably has a pattern of behavior, and that pattern is to get what you want—a woman in your bed.”

He laughed, restrained, his head going back and his eyes closing. “Oh, Janie.”

But she was firm, arms still crossed and looking to make eye contact. “I can’t believe I fell for all that.”

He shook his head now, looking wounded. “Fell for that?—what is that, believe me? You should believe me.”

“I don’t, Maceo, I—”

“Janie,” he said patiently, his arms long enough to cross the distance between them and hook her wrist trying to uncross her arms. She resisted him, pulling back.

“John’s upstairs sleeping, Maceo.”

He let her go, put up his hands, showing her his palms. “You’re crazy if you think I lie to you.”

“Listen, Maceo, you can stay. I’m not calling Home Exchange, I’m not saying anything to anyone. We’re going to continue but you and I are separate. You know what that means...?” She held up two fists touching together, index fingers extended up toward the ceiling then drew them apart.

He watched her for a long moment and she didn’t look away. Slowly his expression began to sink from confident to something more like she wanted to see: bothered. He said, “Okay, it’s true. I seduce you. What I say about your painting is not a lie. That is not a lie. Okay? Don’t think that was to get you in bed. No way.” He wagged his finger, frowning. “I seduce you, yes, I want you in my bed. Course I want you in my bed. You’re beautiful, smart, you are an artist. But you’re here...” Now he wound a finger around in a circle, looking around the kitchen. “Alone.”

“So you feel bad for me?”

“No, no. I’m drawn to you. You have so much need you pull me close...” He made two fists and moved them back and forth between them. “Yes, I seduce you, but you start it.”

“Right, it was me who seduced you. Back to this.”

“No, I know. You’re beautiful. So beautiful. So much life. How can I not be attracted to you? I’m a man.”

“I know I don’t have to say this, but what happened,” she got closer to him, arms crossed still, and whispered, “what happened last night won’t happen again.”

He didn't answer her, kept her gaze, black eyes moving over hers, a spray of stubble on his jaw and chin, chestnut hair raked back. She kept his gaze, and he watched and cocked his head one-way then the other, blinking and breathing. He sucked on his lower lip a moment then let it pop back out.

She said, "John's in bed but he will be up soon. Marissa is on her way with some friends, and I'm going to go and paint. All right?"

He nodded.



In the studio, she studied the work she accomplished last night. She'd torn down her dumb figure drawings and thrown them in the woodstove. There was enough of a coal bed to set them to fire and memory, and she used their immolation to build some heat in the addition, adding lots of kindling.

The work on the easel was different. She already knew that. Even John had seen it. And, most importantly, she felt different about it. It wasn't just trying to replicate something she'd seen with her eye; it was from the heart or somewhere in the vicinity.

Now standing in the warming studio she could see an honesty in it. That was her. Not entirely, but there was something that wanted to be heard. She was giving it voice. Maceo's talk in the kitchen had been the banter of a good-looking twenty-year-old man who probably didn't even know when he was doing something on purpose, pretending that everything came from the heart and soul. Still, his words came bejeweled with possibilities and as she massaged the center of the palm of her painting hand, soothing way stiffness, she could feel the ghost of him against her; the memory of his hard body, the edges of his chest and stomach, the size of his arousal and the soft weight of his testicles cupped in her hand.

It was terrible and vain to admit it, but she *was* beautiful. It wasn't far-fetched to think Maceo was truly attracted to her. If he merely wanted a lover while in America, she was sure there were plenty of young ladies at Chesborough who'd tumble into a dorm room bed or a supply closet with him. And he'd been hanging out with new friends, he'd told her, even going out after class before coming home.

As she sprayed her painting with fixative—she was done with it for sure, and even considered chucking it in the fire, too—the door between the addition and the house opened. She continued to spray, listened as he came up behind her and knew if his arms came around her she'd have to call Home Exchange, she may even have to run up to the bedroom and tell John. But Maceo came and stood at a safe distance behind her and to the side, watching.

She gave the canvas one more spray and Maceo began to prep his brushes and opened thinner. She took her painting down and walked to lean it against the wall near the woodstove. When she returned, Maceo was setting a blank canvas on her easel. She came to stand next to him and he put a charcoal pencil on the easel's tray and backed away, smiling warmly at her.

He said, "Don't give up, Janie."

At his own side of their space now, he finally broke eye contact, turned and took a fine brush, looking to add highlights to the faces of his cousins on the canvas. He worked the paint over them, bringing life to their eyes and shine to their noses, knowing he was being watched the whole time and smiling enough to show his teeth. Smug and masculine and charming. She couldn't help smiling, too.

She picked up the charcoal and moved it across her blank canvas, curious to see what would come.



Down the stairs with Sheba, showered and refreshed, he arrived on the lower level amidst a cacophony of loud and laughing girl voices. Marissa was home with her college buddies, and once they'd shown up sleep was difficult and broken even though he heard Janie reminding them to be quiet because her dad was sleeping. He got a few more hours after his session in the pantry with Janie, and it would have to do.

Marissa saw him first and burst up from the dining room table where she was sitting with her friends and Maceo. "Daddy!" she shouted, and he swelled inside, holding his arms out for her and receiving his little girl. "My big bear," she groaned as she hugged him and he lifted her feet off the floor.

“Hey, angel,” he said and kissed the top of her blonde head before setting her back down on the floor.

“Mom’s making grilled cheese, you going to come play cards with us?”

“I’ll play a hand, sure,” he said, looking her over. Quietly, he said, “This is what you wear to come do laundry?”

When Marissa would bum around the house, stay at the weekend sometimes or over Christmas, her usual attire was a UB sweatshirt, often with stains, sweatpants and fluffy socks and her Birkenstocks; today she wore clean jeans, hip-hugging ones, and a black shirt that clung to her. His daughter was a beautiful girl, looking much like her young mother, and her outfit today was set to remind the Italian houseguest, he figured.

“Dad, shut up,” she whispered, smiling.

“I said it quiet,” he whispered back. She took his hand and led him to the table, saying, “You know, Amy, you met her before, she was here last week, this is Louisa, you met her at the dorm, and this is Amanda, this is her first time here.” He said his hellos and winked at Janie who was at the cookstove attending to three iron pans of grilled cheese sandwiches; she winked back and gave him a head shake which he figured meant she also noticed Marissa’s dressing-up, though it looked like all the girls had as well.

He sat at the table, happy to be with his family. Marissa dealt him in, but her friends, Amy and Amanda, were preoccupied with Sheba who they fell in love with and were rolling around on the floor trying to get her to do cute things. So he chatted with his daughter and she told him how school was going, and Maceo sat with them, too, and talked. Janie served lunch, and the cards were put away, and they all ate together at the big table. Outside, the sky had gone cloudy. Marissa noticed and asked him if he was going to work.

“Oh, yeah. After we eat, I should head in.”

She did her *Oh, Daddy* thing.

He said, “Maintenance, Mar. We got more snow coming tonight and two trucks’ plows with sheared pins, a tranny down and shot to junk, and a whole ton of catch-up I didn’t get to before I had to crash.”

“You going to be here when Evan Skypes?”

“At three? No, honey, I’ll be at the garage.”

She was disappointed, but she was a big girl who had known his winter schedule her whole life. “I’ll say Hi for you,” she said proudly.

“Thank you, baby.”

“A couple hands of cards before you go?”

He agreed and she and the girls and Maceo went in the kitchen and did the dishes and cleaned the pans. Janie came and sat in his lap and he hugged her close. They watched them all in the kitchen and kept up a conversation and he felt good and warm deep inside.

When they returned, Marissa dealt them all in, but Janie said, “Your Dad and I are a team,” and stayed on his lap. They played two games of Hearts, with Janie whispering in his ear, and it was the first time in a long time he felt the ache of having to leave. Work was duty, and he worked hard and never complained, but he was going to miss sitting here.

When it was two o’clock, he swapped with Janie, and she took his seat. He went to the kitchen and poured coffee Janie had made into his thermos and found the meals she’d packed for him in the fridge. Sheba began her stretching routine, and the girls cooed for her and went to give her a hug before she had to go.

He said, “I want you girls on the road before five, you hear me? Be home and safe in Buffalo for six, that’s an order.”

“How much snow’s coming?” Janie asked, and he told her five inches.

Marissa asked, “Can we take the snowmobiles out?”

“Sure, you know the rules, and I mean it, you can’t stay late.”

“We won’t, Dad,” she groaned dramatically.

“Take this guy out,” he said, motioning to Maceo, “give him the full winter experience.”

Janie met him in the kitchen. He said to her, “Tell Evan to call me at the shop, okay? I can’t Skype but I want to say Hi.”

“I will. Be safe.”

“I will.”

They pecked lips because they always kept it G-rated in front of the kids. He slipped his arms around the small of her back, and squeezed himself against her, staring in her eyes and communicating something without words. She read him.

She said, “I don’t know yet, John. I have to think about it.”

LONG DISTANCE

After John left, their game of cards was abandoned and the girls got on their devices. All four girls in the same room not looking at each other, Maceo as well on his phone. Wet laundry sudsed in the washer, dry tumbled in the dryer.

The young people had moved to the family room and were taking up all the spots on the couches. Maceo sat in one corner, Amanda and Louisa on the other, Amy stretched out on the loveseat, and Marissa on the swivel chair next to Maceo, their knees awfully close to touching. They were all sending each other texts and sometimes showing each other on their screens things they were finding funny on the internet. She let them be, returned to the kitchen, opened up her laptop and checked the current time in Rome.

She began making a dough to bake soda bread for breakfast in the morning. Buttermilk, eggs, flour, into the KitchenAid mixer, getting the dough in two round pans and putting them in the cookstove. She cleaned her hands, took off her apron, checked on the family room again.

Maceo and Marissa were sitting together now, shoulder to shoulder, sharing the same screen, both their eyes turned down. Her daughter was beautiful; the same silky blonde hair as her mother, but with a much younger face, a smaller and tighter body. She looked good next to the kid, but Janie couldn't help feeling a spike of jealousy in her, and worry, too—knowing what Maceo was like, knowing his charming abilities and the way he could get a girl into his bed. Would he flash her daughter, too? Show her what he had? Was Marissa *into* that sort of thing? Maceo had a nice body and everything, but what would she think of the guy's manhood?

Now she was clenching her fists and shaking them, thinking of her daughter naked with that guy. That big thing between his legs, Maceo trying to put it inside her sweet daughter. She pushed one of those fists into an eye socket and twisted. The whole thing was stupid, and she had to stop that. Marissa was a grown girl, and not stupid by any measure. It was *she* who was stupid. Stupid and old and ripe for the plucking, and Maceo was about the most handsome young cherry-picker you could imagine. She'd fallen right into his basket with barely a touch. Marissa probably had a bunch of guys burning up her phone or whatever the kids say. Still, she couldn't shake the thought, and hated to see the two of them curled up on the couch together.

She was sitting at the dining room table now, laptop open. She said, "Hey, it's almost three. Evan's going to be calling."

Marissa didn't even answer, stayed side-by-side with Maceo and watching the screen. She nodded, then finally looked up. "Okay," she said, returned her gaze to the phone and laughed at some YouTube video. Maceo did, too.

Then, saving her from further aggravation, the laptop made a bubbling sound of an incoming Skype call. It was Evan. "Hey," she said, clapping her hands, "come on, Marissa."

Now Marissa was in a different mode, jumping up and forgetting Maceo, skipping over to be with her mother; came and swung her butt around and sat on the arm of the chair she was in. The screen blossomed with the heartwarming face of her son, seven-thousand miles away on a different continent, in a different country, a different part of the world with a different family. He looked happy.

"Hi, Mom," he said, beaming. Then, seeing Marissa, his eyes went even wider. "Mar!"

"Hi, Evan!" Marissa practically shouted in her ear.

Now Marissa was waving Maceo over to come and join them.

"How are you, baby?" she asked.

"I'm awesome, mom. It's so great here..." He told them about school, about the engineering program. Marissa kidded him about fudging his grades so they'd accept him over there, asking how much it cost for someone to hack the database. He fake-laughed, then gave her the finger, but Maceo was coming over and she covered the screen so he wouldn't see that.

“Hey, come on now,” she said. Then in the corner of her eye she saw Marissa’s little hand shooting back a hidden middle finger, and she whipped out to cover it up, too. “Knock it off, you two,” she said. Both of them were giggling.

“Evan, baby,” she said, “Maceo’s here. His parents around?”

Evan said they were right here, and he stood up with his laptop, the screen jostling all around the home he was staying in Rome. It was set down and steady on a kitchen table, she assumed, showing a stove and cupboards and glossy tiled backsplash. Behind him were the gathered De Sanctis’s. Mother and father, Maceo’s two sisters, and another girl she could swear was one of the cousins from his painting. All of them shouted when they saw the screen with Maceo looming over her shoulder. He was exuberant, too, crouching down behind Janie, waving his hand near her face, the warmth of his cheek felt on her neck. Bongiorno, Bongiorno, they all said; the girls behind were clasping their hands and his mother looked teary-eyed. She knew the feeling. Maceo’s younger sister crouched down, and Evan stepped back. The sister’s name was Sophia, they’d spoken with the De Sanctis’s before and the young girl served as interpreter.

“Hi, Jane,” she said in a friendly singing.

“Hi, Sophia, how’s it going there? Is my son any trouble?”

“He’s a good boy,” she laughed, looking back at Evan and he rolled his eyes. “He eat all his vegetables.”

She said, “Maceo eats all his, too.”

Sophia said, “Two good boys.”

Maceo’s mother said something in Italian, Maceo nodded, saying si, si.

Sophia said, “My mother wants to know if he’s painting.”

“All the time,” she said, skewing a little to the right so she could glance sideways at Maceo. He looked very happy to see his family.

Maceo’s mother spoke rapid-fire Italian again, and his dad laughed. Then his dad said something in Italian, too, and they all laughed. When Sophia was done laughing, she said, “My mother want to know if he’s eating all your food—he like to eat...”

Maceo grumbled to her, “I told you.”

She said, “No, he’s not. No more than Evan. He is a big boy though.”

Sophia relayed that back to her family. When she was done, Janie said, “He did tell me he was a fat baby.”

Marissa laughed and Sophia did as well, then puffed out her cheeks. Maceo said in a low voice, "You make them very happy, Janie."

"I like your family," she said.

"Me, too."

Marissa said, "Your sister seems so nice." Marissa already making plans for a stay in Italy. Her friends still sat in the family room, but they'd set the phones down and were watching and smiling. Marissa waved to them.

She asked her son, "Are you getting enough sleep, Evan?"

"I sleep like a baby, Mom."

"Would you call your father?"

"Pop's at work?"

Marissa shouted: "Dad says Hi-ii!"

Janie flinched at the volume near her ear, said, "He had to go an hour ago, but he said just give him a call there. He'll pick up. He's expecting you."

"I'll call him, Mom."

Now Maceo's mother crouched down, and Sophia shifted to the side to give room. She spoke in Italian to her son, and he affirmed to her, nodding and saying si, speaking rapidly in Italian. They went on for a while, laughing, his mother cooing like a mother who missed her son, patting her cheeks then blowing him a kiss which his sisters laughed at their brother for.

Maceo's hand came to cup Jamie's shoulder, and he gave her a squeeze. "She's very good to me, mama," he said, seemingly for Janie's benefit.

"I take good care of him," she said, though guilt burned her stomach like a hot coal. Sophia said something quietly that must've been the translation for their mother.

The call was only about ten minutes, there wasn't much more to say, they'd only been gone a few days, and the language barrier made it difficult with so many people involved, but she did miss her son terribly. Each of them got the chance to say goodbye, she and Marissa saying bye to Evan and each of the De Sanctis's getting a turn with Maceo. Then they were all waving, smiling, saying bye, ciao, and the screen was turned off. She sniffed in the silence.

"That was nice," she said to Marissa, feeling a heavy sadness in her voice.

But Marissa was bouncing off the chair's arm, grabbing Maceo. "Let's go snowmobiling," she said. The girls in the family room jumped up. "Yes!" they each shouted in unique ways, doing their young girl affirmations she supposed were drag queens or who knows what they were imitating this year.

She reminded them, "Don't go far, and be home early because your dad wants you on the road before it snows."

"We know."

She added, "Maceo doesn't have a snowsuit—he's too tall for any we have here. Maceo, dress warm, and then put on those coveralls I got you for the chores."

"I'll take care of him," Marissa said.

Amanda said, "We get to play dress-up!" and all of them ran upstairs. She watched the young women leading Maceo up to Marissa's bedroom and dread curled up in her ribcage like a fat house cat by a fire. She had been standing, but now sat back down heavily. She could hear them laughing upstairs, hear Marissa's door opening and closing, opening again, Evan's door opening and closing, closet doors and things being banged, heavy items being slid. The girls were laughing and having a great time—but all she could think of was how she'd just sat there telling Maceo's mother how she took good care of the woman's son. She was doing a terrible job. She'd done horrible things with her son. And if that woman had done with Evan what she had done with Maceo, she would be livid. She would be looking to call the authorities—even though everyone was an adult. She was gnawing on her lip making fists and squeezing her thumb inside them. Something else burning inside her, too. Jealousy. Being separate from him now. Knowing he was upstairs with young girls his own age. That was the way it should be. And if sanity were to resume, this was the way it would remain. This was the way it had to be.

So she let her thumbs go, stretched her hands out. The two middle knuckles of her painting hand ached with the cold and she soothed them. One more blast from the past: the day he tried on the coveralls that were too small with the faded XL tag and how he'd snugged them up his crotch and she could see his manhood pressing it out. The thought that he would do that up there right now with her daughter and those other girls burned at her. But she got up, shook her head, pulled her hair back from her face and went to the kitchen sink. She ran cold water, splashed it on her face. Then there

were feet banging down the stairs again, the house sounding like it did before they were empty-nesters, when the place was always filled with the kids and their friends. She brightened. She turned around to see the five of them tumbling down the steps and laughing, Maceo dressed warmly now, the girls, too, with sweatshirts and sweatpants.

She blinked and worked her mouth around. Marissa saw there was something wrong. She came close.

“You okay, Mom?”

“Yeah, I’m fine, honey,” she lied. How could she ever explain?

Maceo and I used our hands to make each other come, baby.

You cheated on Dad?

Did I?

Marissa said, “You miss Evan?”

“I know he’s at school, anyway, and I hardly see him, but I just somehow feel like he’s so far away. You know?”

“It’s only six weeks long, and it’s not his first time away.” Then her daughter reached up and thumbed away some cold water that had beaded on her cheek. “I love you, Mom,” she said, and kissed the edge of her jaw.

It got her, melted her heart. “Thanks, Mar. It’s just his first time away when he’s grown up. I’ll be okay, I just miss him. You girls go have fun with Maceo.”

Mar said, “We won’t be late.”

The girls and Maceo congregated in the mudroom, and she put her back to the cookstove, warming herself. Marissa helped Maceo into his coveralls because they’d stretched a bunch of warm clothes of Evan’s on his large frame. Mar’s friends all used coveralls and spare snowsuits, and goofed around with each other, taking the opportunity to punch one other when they were so well-padded. The scene made her smile despite the nameless bad feeling settling on her. A nostalgia, a lost time. She was glad her daughter had such good friends and freedom. At Mar’s age, Janie had baby Evan on her teat.

They all left without remembering to say bye, hustled out into the cold, went around the empty animal pens to the barn where John kept their two snowmobiles. She moved to the mudroom and watched out the window set in the door. Soon, the bay door was opening and the headlights of the snow machines shone on the gray snow. It was light still, but the churning in the sky had made the day dark and foreboding. Marissa led the way, easy to

identify in her pink helmet, and Maceo was at her back, arms around her, easy to identify because of his height. The other machine was laden with the other three girls and it bogged down at first but whoever was behind the throttle knew what to do and soon they were all disappearing over the farm field headed to the trails in the woods.

GIRLS

While they were gone, she made shepherd's pie. The sky stayed gloomy, darkening even, and she saw the first few flakes come down, but they tapered off. The wind picked up. She thought of going into the addition and painting—something in the churning sky inspired her—but there was an uneasiness inside her that she didn't feel like fighting against. Instead, with her pies in the cookstove, she went upstairs and brought out her knitting.

In an hour of quiet, dedicated work, she finished a onesie for Stacy's sister's baby. She folded it up, put it in a saved garment box and wrapped a ribbon around it. The pies were done, and it was getting dark and a worry had begun to work at her. Like the kids had run into trouble out there—and then a fleeting notion that they'd gone snowmobiling out to the old ranger cabin, made a fire and begun some sort of naked orgy. She squashed that stupid thought away, and sure enough, scrubbing pans in the sink, she could see dots of light dashing through the distant woods.

Drying her hands, she watched the headlights's shine come out now, breaching the bush and splashing the snow over their pasture. Out front was Marissa, only now she was behind Maceo, her arms around his middle while he manned the controls. She wondered how her daughter taught him the controls; hand over hand, were their helmets off? It bothered her.

The three girls followed behind on the other machine, and they all crested the rolling hills of the farm field, winding their way back to and disappearing inside the barn. The machines' rumble buzzed across the distance then died, and soon the lights were extinguished. Four girls and one very tall young Italian man trudged between the animal pens and onto

the porch. They came into the mudroom shouting, laughing, and hooting. They stomped snow off their boots and lamented the cold, disrobing and throwing their discarded things around them.

She leaned on the doorjamb, asked: "You guys have fun?"

Marissa's friends all had a good time they said, thanking her for use of the snowmobiles. Marissa said they went as far as the ranger cabin and she didn't flinch. Marissa said Maceo was good on the throttle. Maceo said it was wild, and she could tell by his eyes he'd been excited by the thrill.

She asked, "You guys want hot chocolate? Dinner? I made shepherd's pie..."

"No, Mom," Marissa said, "it's late, Dad told us we should go early."

"Okay," she said, and though she hadn't meant it sullen, Marissa must've picked up on something because she cocked her head and made a sympathetic face, saying, "We'll have a hot chocolate, though."

"You don't have to humor me," she said.

Marissa's friend Amy, all rosy-cheeked and bubbling, said, "We're freezing, let me make it," bumbling past and squeezing Janie's shoulder quickly. She went into the kitchen and started a kettle and Louisa and the other one went to help her.

Maceo sat on the bench and struggled his long arms out of the coveralls and Marissa helped.

"I got it," she said, "go be with your friends, Mar." She pulled her daughter aside and guided her toward the mudroom door. "Your laundry is all done. I folded it and put it back in your sacks, okay?"

"Thanks, Mom," she said, disappearing into the kitchen.

"Give me your foot," she said to Maceo, and when he lifted a leg, she pulled the boot off, then the next one. She had him lift his butt up and then tugged the coveralls off, turning them inside out. "Did you really have a good time?" she asked.

"I did, it's fun," he said, looking in her eyes and sweeping the hair back that had fallen in his face. "But very cold."

"You want dinner?"

He thought about it, said, "No, thank you. I don't feel hungry. I think I go have hot chocolate with them, okay?"

"Yeah, sure," she said, and let him up.

She tidied the mess in the mudroom, folded and hung the clothing and lined up boots while Marissa and Maceo and the other girls laughed and

made hot drinks in the kitchen.



After she'd seen Marissa off, telling Amy to drive safe to Buffalo, she asked Maceo if he wanted dinner now. He still wasn't hungry, he said, asked if it was all right if he went and had a hot shower—*he just couldn't get warm*—and she told him that was fine.

While he was upstairs, she ate dinner alone with the radio on. She could hear him up there, could hear the splashing water in the bottom of the shower stall and the rumble in the plumbing. This was the way it should be, but now she didn't even know what to do with herself. She grew uncomfortable. Why would she allow him to stay in her home? Why would she keep this temptation here? *What, Janie, don't think you're strong enough?* She was strong enough. If she felt uncomfortable with him in her home at any time, worse came to worse, she could drive down to Roxie's for a visit, have a pot of tea and an honest laugh and put her world wholesome and right again. What had happened was survivable—and sending him away would produce problems and questions no one wanted.

An hour later, Maceo returned, looking more lively.

"You're warm now?"

"Much better, yes, thank you," he said, standing by the cookstove while she leaned on the sink. He wore shorts and a T-shirt again.

"You're going to paint?" she asked.

"Yes—you come join me?"

Before answering, she looked over her shoulder to see the night black now, and fat, fast-moving snow lit in the porch light as it drifted near the house. John would be out all night. John wouldn't be home until tomorrow afternoon, probably. She played with her necklace. "You go ahead," she said, "maybe I'll join you later."

"Okay, you join me," he said brightly, and she'd anticipated him digging into her with his charm and seducing her to come join him, *Learn the light, Janie, paint from your heart*, but instead he headed to the addition, turning his back on her.

He was being appropriate, the way she'd instructed, but he had her chewing the inside of her cheek. She said, "Keep the fire going in there,

don't let it die down."

"I know, I won't," he said, pausing at the addition doorway as his phone dinged. He stopped, fished it out of his shorts pocket and checked the screen. He went through to the studio and closed the door behind him.

She turned to the sink, looked out the window to the dark, gripped the edge of the counter. She wanted to paint, but not now, not at night, not with John away for hours. *Her* phone dinged now. A text from Marissa.

Mar: home safe, thanks again for everything you are the best!

She set her phone back on the counter, chewing her cheek again, wondering if it was Mar who had dinged Maceo's phone a moment ago.



At 9 o'clock, she decided to go to bed. She stopped at the addition, opened the door but didn't enter. Maceo was busy painting a new canvas she couldn't quite make out, and a fire roared in the woodstove. He stopped and looked over his shoulder.

She said, "I'm going to go to bed."

"Okay, Janie, good night. See you tomorrow."

"Good night," she said, hesitating, waiting for him to say more, but he merely kept her gaze, smiling. She'd love to go in and paint but it was too dangerous; she longed to see what he painted now but knew she had to be the adult. They looked at each other another dragging, agonizing moment, then she said, "Good night," again.

"Sleep well, Janie," he said and returned to his canvas.

She remained in the open gap a moment more, looking at his bare legs and broad shoulders, finally backing out and closing the door. She went upstairs.

In the bedroom, she disrobed and stood in her underwear. Under the hooks by the bathroom door was a pine chair with her painting jeans folded on the seat and her flannel shirt draped over the chair rail. She could just throw those on and go back down, 'shake it off', as Marissa would say. She went to the dresser, withdrew her long flannel nightdress. Bra unsnapped

and off, she shrugged her nightie over her head and down her body and went to brush her teeth.

It was a cold night, so she withdrew another wool blanket from the chest and draped it over the foot of the bed. Slipped under the covers, she stared at the ceiling. Sleep didn't come and the more it eluded her, the less likely she would find it. Now the bedside clock said it was just after 11. She was too warm with the blanket and sat up and pushed it down and off the foot of the bed now. Flopped back, she lay with the bedding up to her middle, hair tangled around her. She should wash it again tomorrow. Marissa really loved it; said it made her look ten years younger, easy. That would put her at twenty-nine. At twenty-nine, Maceo would still be too young for her. *Not Marissa though*. Mar was the right age. The *same* age. And looked good with him, too, even though he was so tall. But she and Mar were roughly the same height—would she look as out of place next to Maceo as her daughter did, height-wise, at least? *Yes, but not his height, Janie, your age*.

"I don't want to *date* him," she said to her room.

Now the image came to her of her mother, crossing one index finger over the other, scraping up and down like she was sharpening it, saying, *shame, shame, shame*. "Not *that*, either, Mother," she whispered to the room. Then *what*?

Nothing. She wanted nothing.

Maybe to paint. Working with him had done something to her heart. That was okay. There didn't have to be anything physical between them. She should have gone in and painted. Why was she so stupid? Was it too late?

Footsteps came up the stairwell, Maceo on his way to bed and trying to step softly, but the old farm house's creaky bones giving him away. She held her breath and listened. He mounted the top step, and she heard Evan's door open and the light switch click on. Then more footsteps, Maceo in her sewing room. She turned her head on the pillow, regarding her door, anticipating him coming into her bedroom. "*I missed you, Janie, you didn't come...*" She swallowed, looking at the sliver of light around the doorframe.

"*I'm twice your age, Maceo...*"

"*But you're so beautiful, Janie...*"

Her hands were under her nightdress, thumbing down the front of her panties, feeling the rustle of her pubic hair under the sheets, eyes still on the

door. Maceo was in the bathroom now, just beyond the wall above her head, brushing his teeth, combing his hair... She shimmied the panties down her thighs, brought her knees out of them and flung them onto the chair with her painting clothes on the other side of the room. Legs kicking the sheets down a little, she undid one more button on her nightdress, drew the hem higher up her thighs and smoothed her hair.

The faucet ran behind her again, then the toilet flushed. Soon, she heard the squeak of the bathroom door, the light switch get flicked. Then nothing. She watched the door again, saw the sliver of light blink out and the room went dark. She held her breath.

But nothing. Minutes ticked by, and she lay there looking at the blank face of a door with John's robe hung on it. Maceo had gone to bed.

TOUCH

It was still snowing when she woke. Out her bedroom window she could see dawning grey sky blotted by the sideways slash of sleet. Her eyes were dry and tired. She'd hardly slept.

"Up and at 'em, Janie," she said, staring still.

She pulled herself out of bed and stretched, knowing she needed coffee before she did anything. In the bathroom, she brushed her teeth, peed, and sitting on the toilet, knew today she wanted to paint. It was daylight. It was light, it was day; she was hungry and passionate for it. That made her smile. But she couldn't ignore the tight knot low underneath her stomach. The smile faded.

She cleaned, flushed, put on her robe and slippers and headed to the kitchen to get a pot of coffee brewing, wondering, too, what Maceo had been working on last night when she'd slunk up here instead. At the top of the stairs, she stopped at Evan's door, peeked in the crack to see her houseguest's big feet below the bunched up quilt. She nudged the door open wider and watched him sleep. The knot tightened.

She'd wake him, rouse him, and they'd have a coffee together, then they'd paint. She went to his bedside, changed her mind, turned away—then turned back again and sat down. His head moved on the pillow, that beautiful face turning toward hers fully, but his eyes remained closed. The urge to flee fluttered through her again, and she shivered.

She whispered, "Mia Vita..."

He made a groaning sound, and she worried her fingers together knowing she should get out of here. Now his eyelashes fluttered, and it was

too late—it would be worse if he woke to see her fleeing, her robe flapping behind her.

His sleepy eyes fixed on hers and her heart muscle flexed; blood rushed in her ears.

“No,” he said, his voice low.

The tips of her fingers went cold, and she repeated, “No?”

“Vita Mia,” he said. “Close, Janie.” He smiled.

“Oh, sorry, oh,” she laughed, a flood of strange relief pounding up and down her neck now.

“Janie, there is no school today. It Sunday.” He drew his arm closest to her out from the covers and cupped the palm behind his head. A flap of sheet folded over and exposed his bare chest to her.

“I know,” she said. “I want to paint. You’ll paint with me?”

“Mm-hmm,” he hummed in affirmation, calm, eyes steady and regarding her.

“You want coffee?”

Eyes still on hers, he gave a single small nod.

She sucked her lips between her teeth and nodded too. He said nothing more, and she had nothing else to say herself, but knew she didn’t want to leave; the idea of leaving was frightening. So she sat there, the sound of her own breathing low but quickening, loud enough she knew Maceo heard. He bit that full lower lip and let it go. The tangle of his hair fell forward, framing one eye. Her fingers untangled, and they felt cold and numb. She rested one hand between them on the warmth of the bed where he’d been sleeping. She inched closer to Maceo; his eyes never left hers. The edge of her hand touched his chest, her wrist bone over the hard muscular disc of his nipple. He didn’t stop her, only watched her face. She moved her hand up; it shook. She lay it flat on his chest.

“You’re warm,” she said, feeling the heat of his body under her palm.

He tilted his head back, showing off his sharp jaw and cheekbones, watching her through narrowed eyes. Her hand slid lower, his skin like silk under her touch. Her heart pounded and her breath came faster. The ends of her fingers took a curl, hooking the edge of the sheet and blanket, lowering them, revealing his sternum and his ribs. His skin shone, lustrous and tanned, tight against the hard edges underneath. Lower she pulled the bedding, revealing his flat stomach now, the tight divot of his navel and the beginning tangle of pubic hair. She paused there, let her hand spread over

his stomach, watched her pale against his tan, watched his skin yield to her touch. The outside light from Evan's window fell flat on them, gray, but he pulsed life.

One finger hooked in the sheets, she drew them down slowly, his pubic hair springing upright as it was exposed. She bit her lower lip. She could see the base of his soft penis, then more, the sheets sliding down his thighs. It was a huge thing, intimidating and masculine, and her eyes returned to his face, aware still in her periphery of that heap of dark brown flesh in his lap. Both of them breathed heavy, watching each other and he bit on his lip again, making her own lips part.

She looked down, raked her fingers through the scruff of pubic hair and rested her palm over the inside of his thigh. His penis lay slung over his scrotum, the end of it dangling down to touch the bedding. Right before her eyes, it began to change. It swelled suddenly fatter, lurching, the cock head filling out and lifting and dragging up the inside of his other thigh. No one touching it, it came to rest on his leg, then rolled over on its back, swelling fatter, then ticked with his heartbeat, sweeping clockwise at the speed of a secondhand, working up to his hip bone, surging suddenly again, lengthening, the end swiftly plumping out. At last, it rose off his body, and she watched the fat head suddenly inflate with excitement, looking like it just doubled in size. She gasped. The most incredible transformation she'd ever seen; ugly and beautiful, thrilling, erotic, terrible. It raced her pulse. She'd watched it blatantly, and yet it was something she should never have seen.

Maceo watched her expression, cocking his head, taking the sheets then and lifting them, inviting her into his bed. She climbed in with him, eyes on his, and he drew the sheets back over her. She lay on her back, his face over hers. Her breath came in quick little gasps now, mesmerized by him, knowing she should run out of here but wanting to stay and see just a little more. He kissed her softly on her temple, at her hairline, his jaw grazing her ear, and her nipples burst into quick buds, making her gasp again and wanting to clutch at them. Her right hand could feel the heat of his body, something resting on her little finger she thought might be one of his testicles.

"Make me come again," she whispered so quiet she feared he might not have heard, and knew she couldn't repeat it.

His hand reached under the sheets, rested over the front of her thigh and drew upward. She squirmed, sighed, *Oh no*, and squeezed her thighs together.

“Relax, Janie,” he said softly, his hand sweeping underneath her nightdress. She wore no underwear and his huge hand moved over her hipbone and stomach, his little finger grazing through her bush. Her thighs shook, but she relaxed, let them settle. She moaned a quavering, reluctant sound when his fingertips slipped down and teased the apex of her slit.

“Oh, mm,” she sighed, feeling the slickness of his touch as he eased between her folds. She was wet.

Arms stiff at her side, her hand fumbled between them, turning and finding a grip on his erection. “You’re so, so big,” she whispered, and began to stroke him.

His hand came out of her nightdress, leaving a chill between her legs were she was damp. He pushed one shoulder of her robe off, then the other, guided her to sit up and she pulled her arms out. Now sitting up, he slipped the nightdress off her body, too, and she folded her arms to stop him. He paused. She let her arms raise, and he continued, pulling it off her with the winter static snap of her hair. She folded her arms again, looking over her shoulder at him laying in her son’s bed and watching her.

“I can’t do this, Maceo,” she said.

He lay his hand on her back and sat with her. After a few breaths, she fell toward him, lay back in bed, both their naked bodies side-by-side. “Just like last time, okay?” she whispered, “Make me come, please...”

“Janie, look at me,” he said.

She was reluctant, blinking up at the ceiling—but she turned. His beautiful face was close to hers, his eyes narrow but sparkling; up close and in the flat gray from the window she could see the lighter colors in his eyes, almond and even gold.

“Just make me come,” she whispered.

The flat of his big warm hand lay on her stomach now, his eyes on hers. “Open your arms,” he said.

She complied, unfolding her arms but not knowing what to do with them now, she rested them at her sides. He raised the hand on her stomach, drawing it toward the ceiling, and it lowered the sheet to bare her breasts. The urge to cover them jolted through her, but she held her breath and watched as the cotton dragged over her sensitive skin, and her bursting

cherry nipples were exposed. They were aching nubs, they grew more erect now with Maceo's eyes on them. In a surge of lust, her hand jumped between his legs, wrapped his huge cock and squeezed.

As Maceo's hand on her stomach slid lower now, heading between her thighs and making her quiver, he kissed her breast. She moaned. His mouth went around her nipple, warm and wet. She moaned again, louder and longer. His fingers stroked through her pubic hair, found her opening and teased. She widened her thighs, pointing her knees outward and touching her heels together.

"Oh, God," she sighed as his tongue began to swirl and tease at the nipple he held in his mouth.

Then he was moving, his cock slipping from her hand, his body lifting the sheets, his pursed lips tugging at her nipple until it popped free. He got over her on his knees, straddling her thighs, naked and unbelievably beautiful. His body was like a sculpture; the skin thin and tanned and stretched over all his hard masculine edges. The excitement had got his strong, young heart pumping, and the veins rose now on his arms and hands; between his legs his huge, engorged manhood stuck out, levitating over her naked body and bobbing with his heartbeat. She studied him, watching up at him with awe, while he studied her laying between his legs—the woman who was supposed to care for him while he stayed in America.

But there was something between them and they couldn't deny it.

It would be so easy to submit to him right now, to open her legs and see if she could accommodate a man of his size, to surrender to rapture and let him take her, but she said, "We can't, Maceo."

He dropped over her on his knees and hands, and her arms went around his back immediately and squeezing at his hard shoulders. His eyes were on hers, face inches away. His cock rested on her belly, hot and ready. He kissed her now, and she let him, opened her mouth to his kiss and felt his passion, fingers turning through his hair. One of his knees lifted and planted between her thighs, and she gasped into his mouth, feeling her opening vulnerable to penetration. His other knee moved between her legs and she opened for him, her own knees stroking up his thighs and squeezing at his hips. She hoped his size wouldn't hurt her but knew it must at first because he was so large.

But now his kiss left her mouth with a soft sound and he kissed her neck. Her hands stroked his sides, going all the way down to his slim waist and back up again. While his mouth explored her breasts, she caressed his head and ran her fingers through his hair. Her body writhed underneath him.

When his kisses went to her ribs, and his knees worked down between her ankles, she began moaning sounds of protest, worrying over where he was headed. But she didn't stop him; *couldn't* stop him. His mouth suckled her navel, his tongue swirled, probed, his teeth nibbled at her soft flesh.

"Oh, no," she told him, but her thighs closed and opened on his ribs and she could feel how excited she was, could feel the seeping wet. She hadn't showered, she'd just peed before coming in here, and no one had gone down on her in a long time.

"Oh God, oh God," she sighed, hips squirming, hands pulling her own hair, fingernails scratching at her scalp, looking down her body between her swaying breasts and rock hard nipples, below the trembling softness of her stomach, seeing a beautiful young man kissing her pubic hair. "Oh, don't," she sighed, but hoped he would.

When his tongue touched that most intimate part of her, she let out a hoarse cry and her hands pounded down at her side; she clutched fistfuls of bedding and twisted them. It was unbelievable; the feel, the intimacy, the surrender—and the willingness of this wonderful young man to deliver her pleasure. *That* was astounding. She'd asked him to make her come—it was him who'd chosen the method. He was an eager lover; eager and beautiful, and young and perfect. He would be incredible, and she *ached* for him.

While he pleased her with his mouth and tongue, she fantasized about surrender; fantasized about him pushing his manhood inside her, claiming her, and her heart thrilled at the thought of being claimed.

In just a few minutes he had her heart rate high and dangerous, and a huge orgasm making itself known inside her, its shape struggling out against the membranes that contained it; knees and elbows poking, claws and teeth trying to tear at the confinement. Down her body she watched his handsome face between her thighs, his muscular, masculine brow, his chiseled young cheeks glistening with her sexual excitement. Her thighs shook; his tanned hands gripped her waist, his thumbs pressing divots into her tummy.

"I'm going to come, oh, I'm going to come," she whispered to him, her fragile voice laced with a whine.

It spurred Maceo, his clutch on her waist tightening, the movement of his mouth quickening and deepening. She covered her face with her hands when she came, her stomach stretching like a cable, her thighs squeezing around Maceo's ears—but it just kept building and her lover didn't stop. She panted to catch her breath, neck straining as her body tightened... And when it wouldn't stop, when it built wilder and wilder, she cried out—a long, breathy wail that filled her son's room with the frightening sound of his mother's lust, passion, and triumphant release. Maceo squeezed every iota out of her orgasm, his tongue chasing down the most insane roller coaster of pleasure she'd ever felt until she twisted on the bed afraid her orgasm would push her into blackness.

Maceo let her go, at last, let her rise on the bed, got out of her way as she twisted and kicked until she was face down on the mattress and she'd clutched one of the pillows, dragging it down and curling her stomach over its balled shape. He'd left her desperate for air, grunting and panting, back heaving up and down. His hands stroked her calves, and she knew she was being watched, her young Italian man most likely pleased the way he'd devastated this pale American mom who'd never had an orgasm like that in her life.

She lay like that a long while, recovering. Flames of guilt, shame, and embarrassment flickered inside, but she shut her eyes, held her breath to extinguish their light and rolled her stomach in waves against the pillow. Pleasure still hummed between her legs.

Maceo wiped his face with a sheet, kissed her thigh, kissed her bare ass cheeks, and the proximity of his mouth to her vulva got her moaning again. He kissed the small of her back, and she managed an encouraging coo. Now he kissed the point of her shoulder and she smiled, opened her eyes. His hand was on the bed by her face, spread out, and she moved to kiss the knuckle of his thumb. With his other hand, he traced hair away, kissed her shoulder again. She closed her eyes. He was tender.

When she opened her eyes again, she bit her lower lip. Maceo lay next to her, on his side, eyes on hers. "You're beautiful when you come," he said.

A scoff blurted from her sleepy lips; the cynical woman inside her pushing away his dramatic, silky words of youth; a young man not knowing what to say in this moment, knowing only to compliment. But her cynicism was ugly. More of 'Janie putting up barriers', like he'd said. His words

were just what a young, romantic man would say to his lover, and if that made her uncomfortable, it was her own fault. For once it would be nice to not try to see through something, but instead to experience it and let it fall over you.

“Thank you,” she said.

“Such a beautiful woman,” he said, eyes moving over her face and down her body. Her hand ventured the distance between them, index finger tracing his chin and touching his soft lower lip. He kissed her finger. Her wedding band shone in the dull light and she closed her hand into a soft ball and tucked it under her chin.

“Thank you for that,” she said, smiling, the two of them face-to-face still. He only smiled in return, eyes studying her.

She’d intended to use her hand on him again but knew what she was compelled to do. She squirmed closer until her shoulder touched his chest. His hand rested on her back, caressed her and she breathed deep, kissed his neck. The pillow was pulled out from under her, and she tossed it behind Maceo, against the wall, as she turned to face him. His arousal was huge between them, upright, the glistening tip resting on the bed. She squeezed it, used the silvery lubrication that surged to trace her fingertip around the swollen end—a *huge* cock head, one she was sure she’d have trouble putting in her mouth. She began to gently stroke him, looking in his eyes then kissing his lips.

As nerves got her, she whispered, “I’m not very good at it,” then knew she should have kept it to herself.

He frowned, said, “At what?”

She sighed. “Blow jobs.” She looked down, looked at his thing in her hand and how her thumb and four fingers barely circled it.

“You don’t have to, Janie,” he said, touching her chin with his thumb to get her to look in his eyes again. “But I want to make love.”

She groaned, closed her eyes and touched her forehead to his chin. He caressed her arm, and she kissed his chest. Then her kisses traveled lower and Maceo leaned away, laying on his back. She sat up, studying his body, admiring him. She looked at his erection, his young, throbbing manhood. She said, “Your penis is really huge. Can girls use their mouth on you?”

He didn’t answer, eyes studying her, but he smiled and gave a soft chuckle, his hand circled her wrist, his thumb stroking the sensitive inside.

It was a stupid thing to say and she better put his penis in her mouth before something else came out to embarrass her.

She scooted down the bed and gathered up sheets, brought them around her shoulders like a shroud, walked her knees over his thigh, avoiding his eyes so she wouldn't feel self-conscious. Looking at him again, she laughed, said, "Maceo, you are so beautiful. You're incredible."

Now she could meet his eyes, only briefly though, lowered them as she crouched between his open legs and began to kiss at his testicles.

Maceo watched her, hand coming down to cup her cheek. She met his eyes for a moment but closed them again and kissed her lips against the underside of his erection. Her kisses worked their way to the end where she slipped the tip of her tongue out and ran it over the cloven underside of his cock head. When she opened her eyes, he was still watching her.

"Make love with me, Janie," he said.

Her hand stroked the underside now, then gripped him near the base, angling his penis toward the ceiling.

"It's so big, Maceo," she said. "You have a big, beautiful dick." She stroked a little, watching the skin bunch around its collar, watched his balls rise and fall.

"Janie," he urged her again.

On her knees between his legs, she gripped his manhood in two hands and wrapped her mouth around the glans. It filled her mouth with its supple shape, the flared rim of it tugging at her lips as it passed. She sunk as much as she could, swirled her topmost hand in semicircles. She bobbed and sucked until her jaw ached. When she took her mouth off, she jerked him. "Do you like that?"

"Yes, Janie."

"Tell me what you want."

"I want you."

"You can come in my mouth."

Now he smiled, his hand cupping her cheek again. She leaned against it, closing her eyes and still stroking him slow and steady.

She asked: "Do you want to come in my mouth?"

"Come up here," he said.

"Am I not doing it right?"

He sat up now, raising his knees, pulling her upper arms, then laying back with her, guiding her so she lay on his body and kissing her on the

mouth. His cock lay over her ass cheek, then came to rest in her crack.

“I can’t, Maceo,” she whispered.

But she straddled him still, knees on either side of his waist, curling her back forward, hands on his chest, until his cock fell between them, laying on his stomach. She lowered to sit on it. The split of her sex was divided over the raised ridge that ran up the belly of his cock. She slid up and down, tilting her hips forward and rocking them back.

“That’s it,” he groaned.

“I can’t put it inside, Maceo.”

“Just like that, Janie,” he said, putting his hands over top of hers on his chest.

She humped against him, scooting her slippery little opening up and down his shaft, watching the wrinkles on it, the gathering skin below the head, sometimes it would even swallow it up. His tip spewed male lubricant, and it beaded in the tangle of body hair above his navel. It was so incredibly erotic that at one point she almost surrendered, wanted him to gore her, wanted to know how full he would make her canal...

Her own excitement had left the poor young man’s cock shimmering. But when she scooted forward, giving in to desire, looking to impale herself, she fought for control, digging her nails in and kissing his neck instead.

And now she had him close. She could hear it in the depth and quickness of his breath.

“Yeah?” she asked him.

When he nodded, she scooted between his legs, got on her knees and took him with both hands. She jerked him hard and fast—he was slick—then got him in her mouth again, pressing her tongue against the soft spot below his hole. The thing swelled against her palette, and he grunted, then roared. Semen filled her mouth, and she gagged but held on. Then it was squirting against her throat and she was swallowing, surprised by the amount and force, but determined to be good for him.

She wrestled it, squeezing it tight with both hands, snorting through her nose and squinting through his orgasm.

Finally it abated and she could breathe again, holding him in her mouth still and gently stroking him. She let her lips come to a point on him, let his cock fall back and slap heavily on his tight stomach. He was so hot.

She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, watching him still bask in the pleasure she delivered, a good and warm feeling wavering outward from her core.

MESSAGE

Now it was over, the shame returned; while she admired him and his youth and perfection, she could feel her face grow hot.

“Oh, no,” she moaned, falling forward and settling on the bed next to him, facing away toward Evan’s dresser. Maceo’s hand rubbed on her back. “I shouldn’t have done that.”

“It was good,” he said.

“Thank you,” she said, grimaced, shook her head. “No, I shouldn’t have done it.”

“You came to me, and I wanted you...”

“Oh, God,” she sighed, feeling his body spooning against hers, and she watched that good-looking hand curl over the narrow of her waist. “I know,” she sighed. “I want to be with you...”

“I want to be with you, too,” he said, his hand searching for hers, finding it, enclosing it.

“It’s not...” she paused, sighing again, knowing she could never explain to him the complex feelings at work here. “I shouldn’t have...” She watched her hand held in his, liked the contrast of their skin tones, the contrast of her feminine to his masculine. “I shouldn’t have *swallowed*.”

“You didn’t have to, Janie,” he said, nuzzling closer, his chin on the crown of her head.

“I don’t even *do* that,” she said pleadingly. The use of her mouth had ended in high school, and once she was a mom, sex became meat-and-potatoes and she was fine with that. Happy with it. She’d done this now with Maceo for what reason? To impress him? Show him she was as good as those young girls he was surely with back in Italy. Part of her knew, too,

that she was probably Maceo's first older woman and that he probably had the impression that older women were wildcats in bed—that because of their age they'd already done it all and seen it all and weren't squeamish and could show a young man a thing or two. So with that in mind, she'd used her mouth, sucked him and let him ejaculate in her mouth. And had swallowed it.

"It's okay, Janie," he said, voice low, "don't think about it. Be happy."

"I am happy," she said in reflex. She could feel him chuckling behind her and it made her mad—this young man, just past twenty, thinking he was wiser than her, always acting like he knew her better than he did, and she allowed it. Why?—because he was a better artist than her?

She squirmed around to face him, thinking she would scold him, but changing her mind when she looked in his deep eyes. She made another scoffing sound, rolled her eyes. "I'm happy, Maceo."

"I hope so," he said, slipping his hand between them and laying it flat on her chest.

She watched his eyes a while longer. She said, "I can't make love. I won't cheat on John. Letting you... do that... in my mouth is closer to cheating than just using my hand. That's all I can do."

"You think he won't care you use your hand?"

"Of course he would..."

"You don't decide, Janie."

"Decide what?"

"What is cheating."

"Who does?"

"The other person."

"Oh, I know. I just..." She shook her head. It was too hard to explain. Too much work to find words to describe what she felt. But of course there was fear, too, that in searching for the words she would find none, she would discover there was no rationale. It was safer to know in her heart how much she loved John and everything else was just annoying detail. "I love John," she said.

"Okay," he said.

She'd prefer he said 'I know,' like he'd seen it with his own eyes and knew it to be true. 'Okay' sounded like he didn't believe her.

"I do, you know."

"And then we only use our hands."

“We only use our hands,” she said.

Eyes on hers, the hand he held between her breasts lowered, going down her stomach and up her waist, caressing her hip, then a buttock. “I like to use my hands,” he said.

“Uh-huh,” she grunted brightly, heart rate picking up as she wondered what he intended.

His hand swept the back of her leg, to just above her knee, cupping her and encouraging her to draw her leg upward. She brought her knee to his ribs, her sex fully exposed. His hands moved up the back of her thigh, coming slowly up to her slit that had begun to throb in anticipation of his touch.

“Oh, yeah,” she sighed as his lips came closer and they kissed. His fingers teased at her and she rolled her hips toward him, hiked her knee higher up his body, squeezing her thigh against him. She moaned into his mouth as he penetrated her with two big fingers and began to stroke in and out. He was slow and careful, seeking to give her pleasure. He had her squirming against him and panting in just a few minutes.

She gasped, “Ah, will you, mm, paint me?”

“You want me to?”

“Oh, yeah, mm, please...”

“You pose for me?”

“Oh, mm, yeah,” she grunted, clutching his shoulder and sinking her nails in him. A switch was flipped inside her, mechanisms clacking, floodgates opening and an approaching orgasm beginning its travel preparations. “John... he wants...”

She was quiet for a long time, her lips sucked in and clamped between her teeth, her naked body gyrating against his penetration.

“Wants...?”

“Oh, ah, he wants you to paint me...”

“He *wants*?”

Her hips humped against him and her hand grabbed and squeezed at his arm.

“He *wants* that. Paint me...”

“You pose?”

“With, ah, a bare, mm, breast...”

“He want me to see it?”

“Ah, he does...”

“I paint you for him.”

“Yeah?”

“I paint you beautiful. We make him cry...”

“Don’t...”

“We show him, show him how you look, show him what he can’t see...”

“I... Don’t make him cry...”

“Cry because he happy—I show him how beautiful you are...”

“That’s what he, ah, wants...”

“He know, but he forget...”

“We’ll show him,” she grunted in a squeak, feeling an electric tangle in her stomach getting it fluttering. “Kiss me, kiss me,” she demanded, and Maceo rolled over her, his big lean frame over hers, her arms locked around his neck, two big fingers bound together as large as a cock pushing in and out of her and she raised her knees high, the soles of her feet curled over the muscle of his hips.

Her second orgasm came as their mouths locked and she sucked on his tongue. This one was polite and reserved, not kicking her over and making her babble, just pure heart-racing thrill. She clawed his back and snorted around her kissing.

Soon they both stilled and even Maceo breathed heavy. She caressed his back and her canal squeezed and gripped his fingers, holding onto the vestigial scent of her orgasm. The kisses became gentle. He withdrew his fingers and caressed her pussy with his large hand.

“You’re incredible,” she said. “You make me come so easy.”

“I can’t wait to paint you.”

“Today?”

He nodded, studying her.

“Lay with me?”

He did, putting himself next to her on the bed and drying his hand with a sheet. She gave him her back, burrowing into him, wanting to be held, moaning with satisfaction when his arm came around. She took his hand in both hers and held it to her chest. His cock was hard again, pressing into her back.

“Want me to use my hand? I can make you come again—I *want* to...” she whispered.

“Later, Janie, I want to lay with you now.”

“God, yes,” she sighed a long exhale and closed her eyes. Tension had left her body, her neck and back felt like warm liquid and her heart beat heavy and happy behind her ribs. In minutes she was fast asleep...



Something troubled her and she couldn't place what it was. Eyes closed, she squinted and a series of twitches flickered through the muscles of her brow; she blinked and blinked though her eyes were already closed. When they eased open, there was great light.

She was face-to-face looking into deep and knowing eyes.

Her own eyes narrowed, eyelashes fluttering. A happy flood that had soaked up from her core and spilled over her shoulders and caressed down her arms whispered away like a ghost. She emptied, and that warmth in her center turned to a cold hard stone.

The face was a wolf's.

The eyes were blue. Tufts of white fur ran its muzzle, black stripes up the center and over the crown of its head. The wolf wasn't angry, only stared at her. The triangles of its ears sat pricked upright, its head cocked at a haughty angle.

Not a wolf. A dog. Her dog. John's dog. Sheba.

The dog yawned now, closing its eyes, stretching its jaws wide, that pink dangling tongue curling then flopping between pointed, dangerous looking teeth. The mouth closed, and Sheba resumed that awful, penetrating stare...

Awful instant realization slapped her across the face harder than her father ever could. She jolted and jumped. The movement was involuntary; an electric lightning shock seizing her body. Her feet kicked at the sheets—

She was in Evan's bed!... She was in Evan's bed with another man. *John was home, oh God, oh sweet Lord, John was home, her loving John was home...*

She fell out of bed onto her hands and knees, her breasts shaking and swinging; she clutched one arm across herself, scrambled to her feet, knees together, fell against Evan's door, leaning on the jamb. Then she was darting over the space of her sewing room, completely naked, bewildered, ashamed, and profoundly humiliated. She fell against her bedroom door

hitting it with her knee, shoving it open before whipping it closed behind her... stopping short of slamming it, and gently clicking it closed.

How did this happen? Oh my God, how did you let this happen? Did he know? Did he see?...

She backed away from the door, sat herself on the bed. Hands gathered between her legs, scratching through her pubic hair, she sensed the warm, sticky damp beneath. She'd cheated. She'd been with another man. His penis didn't go inside her, but it might as well have.

"Oh God, no," she sighed, brought her hands up to bury her face. Maceo's smell was on her hands. The scent of his body, his musk, stale residual deodorant, and worse smells, too, the product of his sexual excitement.

"No, no, no," she moaned, rocking back and forth.

Then with a brisk closing, a quick snap like somebody doing up a zipper, all her thoughts were closed off and she was moving again, fast, grabbing panties from her chair, striking her legs through them, putting on her jeans... John's old flannel was snatched up, she thrust closed fists through the sleeves—no time for a bra, but it didn't matter—and her fingers were moving like lightning doing up the buttons, starting them askew, undoing them, doing them up again, moving quick. Then she was out, darting into the sewing room and closing the bedroom door behind her.

Be strong, Janie, be strong, she whispered to herself.

She smelled strong, fresh coffee. John was in the kitchen. Or had been. Maybe he was gone now. She would go down to the kitchen and find a gurgling coffee maker, her husband tearing off in his pickup truck, racing down the hill like a madman after what he'd discovered.

"No, oh no," she said, "oh my God, oh no..."

She took another step toward the top of the stairs. Evan's door was open, and she moved quicker now, sweaty bare feet sticking on the glossy old pine. She made it to the stairs, took Evan's doorknob and closed the door. Two steps down, she remembered her clothes were in with Maceo. It was no matter now. It was too late. He would hide them and if he didn't, he was a fool. Or evil.

Now she was chewing on her lower lip, taking one more tentative step down toward the landing. She peered over the edge to the second set of steps descending into their family room, bright light filling the lower level.

How did she let this happen? The snow had stopped. The storm passed over...

She'd slept in bed with another man. Her husband had been out working, the snow had stopped. He came home.

Oh, you're bad, you're so so bad... Her mother's voice, rising up from the grave to remind her.

"I'm not bad," she said aloud. And now she suddenly sat down, both her knees giving gentle pops and her bottom thumping on the hard surface. She buried her face in her hands again. "I can't do this. I can't even... I can't do this," she whispered into her hands, covering her eyes and rubbing her fingers over her brow.

You can do it, Janie. You can do it—you have to...

She sniffed, felt wet on her fingertips. Shit, she was crying. With the back of both wrists covered by John's flannel, she rubbed at her eye-sockets; sniffed again, cleared her throat. Two more frightened steps down to the landing, her feet and lower legs now lit up from bright wintry light. She descended further. Coffee was on, and John was cooking. She smelled eggs, she smelled cheese. John hadn't seen her.

"Oh God," she sighed. *He wouldn't make breakfast if he'd found her like that, now would he?* "Oh God," she sighed again, sniffled wetly.

Okay, okay...

She descended to the main floor, tried to brighten her face, moved around the chimney and into the kitchen.

Standing at her stove was a tall, striking man. Young, handsome, wearing slim fitting T-shirt and shorts—it was Maceo. Not John. She stopped short, her bare foot making a small squeak on the wood floor. Maceo turned and smiled.

She said, "What's going on?"

She expected him to look at her surprised, perhaps put a finger up to his mouth to indicate for her to shush because John was nearby. Arms folded across her chest, she took two hurried steps around to stand by the warm woodstove, peering around the other side of the stone chimney to find where her husband was.

Maceo said, "I'm making breakfast."

"Okay," she said, sounding her most innocent. Then she mouthed *Where is he?*

Maceo didn't understand. She took two more steps to the kitchen counter island, rested her elbows on it, peering out the windows looking for John on the porch. Maceo came to the opposite side of the counter and leaned on it, close to her.

She stepped back, saying, "Whoa."

"What's wrong?" he asked.

"Where is he?" she whispered.

"Who?"

"John—Where is John?..."

"I don't know," he said.

"He's here," she said, barely uttering the words but mouthing them clearly so he understood. "He's home..."

"John is?"

She stepped back again, turned, trotted into the dining room to peer out the windows. She could see the top of the driveway between the shoveled path that divided their gardens and saw nothing but her own pickup and Evan and Marissa's Yukon next to it. John would have parked lower down the hill.

She trotted back, said, "You didn't see him?"

Maceo shook his head. He said, "I've been up for fifteen minutes. I go and do chores, I feed chickens, bring in eggs. Look," he motioned to the pan and smiled, "I make a big breakfast for you."

"O-kay," she said, "that's great. You didn't see him?"

"He's not here, Janie."

She frowned, her bottom lip curling, canine tooth clamping down to pinch it. She left Maceo alone in the kitchen, trotted into the mudroom now. Legs pushed into a pair of coveralls, she shoved her bare feet into rubber boots, put on her barn coat over top, and donned a fuzzy hat. She walked out the mudroom door into the frigid cold.

Snow had accumulated overnight, burying their paths to the barn and between the pastures. The covered porch was clear though, and she moved around past the kitchen window, Maceo watching from inside with a frown on his face trying to figure out what she was doing. She walked past the front door and the dining-room windows, along the path between the gardens to the trucks. She looked down the driveway. It hadn't been plowed overnight. John hadn't been here yet. There were no tracks. John wasn't here.

How was John not here, but Sheba was?

She took a few more steps down the driveway to see if he had backed into the turnaround. No. *Plus, Janie, what's wrong with you?—he would leave tire tracks, his damn truck didn't float.*

"What the hell is going on?" she said, rubbing her temples. "What is going on?"

She trudged back the way she came, past the front door again, waving at Maceo who still watched her from the warmth of the kitchen, brow knit with concern. Into the mudroom again, she undressed, returned to the kitchen in just a flannel and shorts and bare feet. She said, "He's not here."

"I tell you."

"Sheba was here. Where is Sheba?"

"Sheba is not here, Janie."

Had she imagined it? She said, "You haven't seen my dog?"

"She go with John."

Of course she did. And the truck wasn't here. John didn't drop her off and leave again without her. He wouldn't do that. She'd imagined it. It was a dream. *Maybe a message.*

"Oh my God," she said and collapsed, falling against the kitchen counter and laughing. She laughed so hard, tears came. Her hair fell over her face, spreading on the counter, her breasts mashed against it. She heard Maceo laughing as well.

"What's wrong with you?" he said.

"I'm just going crazy. That's all. Nothing to worry about. I just... I'm going crazy."

His large hand spread on her back and she didn't shy away.

It was a dream. It was just a dream.

He caressed her, squeezed her shoulder. "Look, Janie. Come get something to eat. I make breakfast for you."

She laughed again, stood upright, ran her hair back from her face and dried her eyes. "Holy cow," she said. "Oh wow, that was crazy. My heart is racing."

Maceo turned her so they faced. He looked down on her warmly, she loved looking up into his dark eyes especially when he looked at her this way. He said, "You thought John was here?"

"I did. I woke up and Sheba was there in the room."

“There is nobody here, Janie. It’s just you and me, and we are all alone.”

He put his hand over her heart to feel if it was beating fast like she said. She asked, “Is it racing?”

He dipped his hand lower, let it fall to her waist, then dragged it back underneath the flannel going up against her bare skin. He put his hand between her breasts and her knees went watery. She held his hand over top of the flannel looking up into his eyes. She asked again: “Is it racing?”

“You are very scared.”

“Wow, was I ever,” she laughed. “I can’t believe that happened.”

His thumb caressed the softness of her breast, very near her nipple, and her toes scrunched up on the kitchen floor.

He said, “It was a dream, Janie. Nothing to worry, it’s just you and me.” He dipped lower to kiss her, and she turned her mouth up to his. Their lips met, her hand came up to touch his neck. But then even though the danger was over she had a sudden flash of John standing at the front door. He would see her standing in the kitchen with their young Italian houseguest, the handsome man’s hand stuck up her shirt and the two of them embraced in a kiss. She pushed him away but gently. Their lips made a smacking sound.

She smiled. “Don’t kiss me like that. Not when it’s light.”

“We are alone, Janie.”

“The snow stopped, Maceo.”

“Okay,” he said, smiling, stepping backward now, putting his hands up in surrender. “If we don’t kiss, then we eat.”

She chuckled, folded her arms over her breasts, felt her nipples hard. “Sounds good to me,” she said.

RENDER

For breakfast, Maceo prepared scrambled eggs with four different kinds of cheese—quattrofromaggio. He'd sauteed onions, too, and some mushroom to go along. Coffee was ready, and while they ate the eggs standing at the island, she put bacon in the oven. The radio was tuned to a classical station, just soft piano and strings in the background. She told him she read they don't eat eggs for breakfast in Italy. He said they didn't. She asked if they even ate eggs at all. He said his mother used them for baking and sometimes she would give him a hard-boiled one when he was little. When the bacon was done, they ate that both still standing in the kitchen in bare feet, their toes close together and almost touching. Dishes and pans were tossed in the sink to be done later. She'd looked at him and said, "Let's paint."

Now they were in the studio side of the addition, both of them at their easels and dabbing away while a wet log popped in the stove. This new canvas was fun. The emotion in today's sky wasn't grim and heavy with meaning, it was light and playful. Much like the sky outside their windows today; renewed and rested after the overnight storm.

John would be home soon, looking for food and sleep. The things she'd done with Maceo would be compartmentalized and stored; put away like a rarely used brush or utensil, clipped inside a box, tucked in a tie-top satchel, put in the lower level tier of her secondary work box and tucked inside a closet. What she'd done was merely physical. Love for John wasn't diminished in any way—in fact, you'd be crazy not to notice things were better between them. That brought a smile and a funny happiness had her hand flicking pale peach to the underside of some pleasant looking clouds.

The smile turned to a happy chuckle, and she stopped, stepped back, liking what she saw. Another landscape. Brand-new. Was it the same sky? The same sky as the last painting, only the morning-after? She didn't know. The end of the long paintbrush she was using clattered a tapping sound as she flicked it up and down between the rows of her lightly parted teeth.

"Hey," she said to Maceo without looking over at him. He came to her side still holding his own brush. "What do you think?"

Maceo studied it without saying anything.

She interjected: "Can art be cheery? Does it have to be melodramatic to be real?"

"You know that's not true," he said, still studying.

"Does this feel real?"

"Is it real?" he asked her.

"I painted it," she joked.

He made a reluctant grumbling laugh, leaned to set his paintbrush on the worktable. "Yes, you paint it, Janie, I see you paint it." He took her shoulders and turned her to face him. She tilted her chin up and pouted her lips out as far as they would go, set her paintbrush in a level mustache line between her curled-out upper lip and her nose, and held it there, putting her hands down. He smiled, and she loved to see it.

"I think it's real," he said, taking the paintbrush out of her philtrum clench and setting it on the table next to his.

"Why?"

"You are in a good mood, yes?"

"I paint from my heart," she said, mimicking his accent in a comically thick Italian.

"Yes," he chuckled, "you paint from your heart."

Hands moving from her shoulders, he began undoing the topmost button on her flannel shirt.

"What are you doing?" she asked in a coy sing-song.

"You paint from your heart so it's real. That is all that matter..." He undid the second button.

"I'm not wearing a bra," she whispered, looking down and watching his hands work.

"I know, Janie," he said, undoing the third. Now her shirt was open from navel to neck. With the tip of his long index finger he poked the collar of her shirt to the edge of her shoulder's downward slope. Then pushed it

over. Gravity took the too-big shirt, one of John's, and it slumped down to her elbow completely exposing one of her breasts. The point of her nipple condensed to a bud, hard and fast.

"John can be home any second."

The feel of his hand on her bare shoulder produced an involuntary groan, and she wavered from side to side. Her stomach tightened. His hand eased down and cupped her breast, curled-back thumb drawing a feathery circle around her areola. She imagined being in bed with him right now, the two of them naked, icy snow battering hard against the windows, demanding John as far away as Cheektowaga; they were naked, the master bedroom fireplace glowed with a small crackling fire, and there were no rules, no rules at all...

"Hands only," she said, "remember."

The hand on her breast dropped and held her wrist as he stooped. "And mouths," he said before taking her nipple in his mouth, the point of his slippery tongue caressing its shape. She moaned, rocked on her heels.

"Hands and mouths only," she sighed.

He suckled on her gently and she cupped his neck then stroked his jaw with her thumb.

She said, "We can't, Maceo, John could be home right now..."

His lips came to a point on her nipple and he pulled it taut until it popped free and the flesh of her breast shook. He stood straight again. "It's for John."

She smirked, thinking he was just being devilish. She said, "Oh, is it really?"

The wrist he held was guided to fold over her ribs just under her breasts; he took the other hand and moved it to the opposite elbow. Her shirt slumped down one arm, billowing at her elbow, her breast still bare, the hard nipple glistening wet. Maceo said, "Step into the light like that, let me paint."

"Paint me?" she said, liking the sound of it and an unstoppable smile spreading on her face.

"For John. You said he want."

She looked down at her bare breast and laughed. "Oh, my Lord, he would die."

"We kill him, yes?" Maceo laughed.

“Oh, wow, I don’t think so,” she said, chuckling, tugging a fold of her shirt so her nipple was covered.

“Be bold, Janie,” he said and gripped her shoulders with both hands. “You said he want.”

She groaned and chuckled, looked down at her bare breast. “I said that. He wants it. Maybe not the breast bare. I think he said that in the moment...”

“Let me...”

Now she looked up at him again. “I think John really wants it. Is that crazy?”

“What did he say?”

“He loves the drawing you did. I mean, Maceo, he really loves it.”

“It make him happy...”

She nodded, smile spreading. “It does. Happy and something else. And I think... he wants more, he wants a sexier picture...”

“We give it to him, yes?” His hands on her shoulders tried guiding her toward the light coming in the big windows. She resisted. He paused to hear what more she would say.

She whispered, “I think he likes when you look at me.”

She’d expected puzzlement from his expression, but saw only understanding—and a slight nodding of his chin as though he anticipated more to the story.

She said, “That’s it. I just think he likes that you see me, I don’t know, maybe the way he sees me.”

“Any man see you, Janie, he see you’re beautiful.”

“It’s more than that,” she sighed, slumping, her neck suddenly not strong enough to support the weight of her head. She let herself be guided toward the window, still clutching her shirt around herself, her breast bare. Maceo took her into the bright daytime light spilling in from the outside; the cold of the glass prickled at her bare arm and her nipple tightened further. She tugged her shirt again to hide it. Maceo moved the fabric away, exposing it, then running the pad of his finger over the bud and making her thighs tighten.

She asked, “Can I sit?”

Maceo brought a stool over, wound the seat around until it’s height came near her bottom. She leaned against it rather than sitting. He studied her, face serious, standing a few feet back, those dark magic eyes moving

all over her. Her stomach tightened hard and the inside of her thighs began a tremble. She chewed and sucked on her lower lip.

As he stepped further back, heading for the easel, a grimace tightened her features. Out the other side of the addition, John's side, she could see the wraparound porch, the mudroom door, the path down to the chicken house; John could come around that corner any second, bypassing their front door and heading to the mudroom. His head would most likely be down, but if he were to look up, would her husband be ready to see this?

She thumbed up the flannel and covered her breast. Maceo saw, made no expression.

She said, "We can't do this now, Maceo. John will be home."

"He be happy with this..."

"No. Maybe... I'll have to get up, I'll have to make him something to eat..."

"We won't be long..."

"There's no time to paint me, Maceo... Maybe if John goes to bed after he eats..." *And what, Janie, you're going to pose with a breast out while your husband sleeps off his night shift under the same roof?* This was too crazy...

Maceo held up a charcoal stick. "Draw then? No paint..."

She considered it, chewing on her lower lip again, trying to hold on to it while a smile wanted to pull it thin. "Okay," she whispered. Now she thumbed down the fabric of John's shirt, not exposing the nipple but getting very close. She tilted up her chin, shook her hair so it tickled her bare shoulder and down one side of her back.

"We have to stop right away as soon as John gets home."

Maceo smiled with a satisfied look in his eyes; he'd won a victory here. That fact made a part of her soar; this man *wanted* to draw her. She could use the excuse that this was for John to make her feel better but really there was profound excitement in being more than your *husband's* muse. Maceo's desire to render her with his beautiful hand was the kind of thrilling she couldn't express. A deep and pervasive crawling through her insides, a feeling of badness and good, of value and vulgar baseness; a startling revitalization of womanhood.

As Maceo began working on a sheet of paper he'd clipped to the easel, a strange thing happened. Maceo would regard her, move his eyes back to the paper, his hand moving fast then slow, his movement graceful, his eyes

would return to her. After a while, it was as though his hands were on her; she could feel his caress, the ghostly reminder of his large hands on her bare skin this morning in her son's bed. Her bared but hidden nipple began to ache, so did the other, scratching and poking against the inside of John's flannel, dragging the cotton with each breath. Her stomach ached low, like tightening knots just inside the points of her hipbones. Her breaths grew ragged and deep. Still Maceo worked away studiously, seriously, his brow lowered with concentration. She watched him, watched his masculine grace, his black and intelligent eyes measuring so much of her and translating it by hand onto paper. He was magnificent. Young, handsome, tall, talented, deep; he was perfect, so incredibly perfect. As time ticked away the only worry was John would appear on the porch, hunched over from the cold, his tattered work jacket up around his shoulders, collar up to protect his neck, stomping his boots before entering the house. That would end this spell, and she wanted this to go on forever...



The blade dropped at the flick of the dashboard toggle, hydraulics groaning after a brutal thirty-hour shift on the road. Then the Ford was pushing snow up the hill, heaving it off to the right side of their driveway, all the way to the crest. He cleared the turnaround, backing up, then driving the snow to the opposite side with the nose pointed downward. Back up again, then taking two more passes up and down, cleaning up around the back of the kids' Yukon and Janie's pickup. He'd finish the rest by hand, but he needed to sleep first. Or, maybe Janie could get Maceo to go and do it.

"Holy crap, Sheba," he said as he backed the Ford into the turnaround, and set the shovel down. Two forearms draped across the top curve of the steering wheel, he lay his hot and sweaty forehead down and felt like he'd pass out. "Girl, I am *so* damn tired."

His guts ached, too. It was almost thirty hours straight sitting in this vehicle except for a few times he'd got out to stretch his legs or push a shovel around someone's walkway. He stopped at Dunkin' a few times, got a couple coffees, and ate all of what Janie packed, so he'd grabbed a cruller, too. That was five in the morning. Now it was what? Two o'clock in the afternoon?... His stomach burned like he'd eaten a battery.

He groaned, hoisted himself back to lean his head against the rest. “I gotta get up, Sheba. I do not want to fall asleep sitting in this damn truck...”

Sheba wouldn’t let him. She was home now, excited, looking to lay by the fire, maybe run around a little and see what Janie was up to. She was up with two paws on the passenger door ledge, tail wagging.

“Yep, yep, I know,” he said, pulling back the lever on the door and getting punched in the face with an ice cold breeze.



They were standing side by side, shoulders touching, leaning close and looking at his drawing. Feathery black charcoal lines described her form; shades of graphite gave it depth. Bright daubs of gouache put sparkle in her eyes, lit up her cheekbone, put shine on her lips and the curve of her nose. A woman standing next to a window; though there was no background, the lighting was clear and told the story. The light traced the curve of the woman’s shoulder, her husband’s shirt falling down one arm and almost exposing a breast. Maceo’s eyes had seen this woman, his talented hand had transmitted onto the paper the flesh of her. It was incredible.

“It’s... *incredible*, Maceo. I don’t know how you do it. You’re just so amazing. Oh my God...”

“You think he like?”

“Oh, yeah, wow, will he ever.” The paper was trembling, and she realized it was traveling from where she held it with one hand. “What are we doing?” she asked him.

“We having fun, yes?”

“We are,” she said, afraid to look at him, eyes glued to the way he’d rendered her. Her stomach was at once a tight column but behind that it was weak and watery. Her insides felt like sludge, her hipbones held those aching knots again. Her thighs pressed together, she kept tightening her pelvic floor. Her hips were squirming. “You’re so incredible,” she said again, finally taking her eyes from the paper.

Maceo held it still, admiring his own work. Or at least she thought, because then he said, “It’s you. It’s you that is incredible. If I draw a perfect piece of fruit nobody care.”

“I think *I* could draw fruit. Nobody is impressed by that.”

He didn’t answer, still studied her own face looking back at them from a sheet of paper. Then his forearms were flexing as he rolled up the paper, grabbed a short strand of twine on one of the work tables and tied it around to hold it in a scroll. He dropped it on the table and turned, leaned on it with his hands curled on the lip and watched her. The sky was bright above them out the window, and his frame was broad-shouldered and masculine. He held her with his gaze, those black eyes looking into her, knowing smirk pulling his mouth askew.

She said, “You’re so talented. So amazing,” and she closed the distance between them. Soon her bare feet were between his bare feet, her hands on his ribs, moving to caress his hips. “So amazing,” she said.

With a bent knuckle, he pulled her chin upward, stooped and lowered his mouth. She went on her tiptoes so they could kiss. If John came around the corner now, it would all be over. All the fun would be done. But she kissed him anyway, pushed her tongue into his mouth, felt the strong ring of his lips tug at hers, his slippery tongue pushed into her mouth. His hands went to her waist, and hers went down his thighs.

“I can’t keep my hands off you,” she said.

“I can’t keep my mind off you,” he mimicked. And they were breathing heavy, mouths sucking on one another, her fingers curled the bottom of his short leg, tugged it higher until his penis fell out. He was engorged but not hard. She gripped it and pulled downward, milking him while they kissed. “I can’t keep my hands off you...”

“Let’s go upstairs, Janie...”

“We can’t—come on, Maceo, look outside, John’s truck could be pulling in the driveway right now...”

She wouldn’t go upstairs, but she felt her body lowering until she was on her knees between his legs. She kissed the inside of his thigh above his knee, hand gripping a handful of his shorts leg, pushing it higher getting his penis to emerge and dangle again. He wore no underwear, and she admired his manhood lit up bright in the studio. An absolutely incredible piece of equipment. It was growing hard again, just like she’d watched this morning when it lifted off the bed and wound itself up to lay on his belly, raise up hard as a bar and as big as a peppermill. “God, I love this thing,” she whispered, “everything about you is so amazing...” She kissed the head of his penis, spread the wet ring of her mouth around its supple shape and

drew it in. She ran her tongue up and down the underside, dragged her teeth over its hardening shape, pulling with her neck to draw it longer, encouraging her young lover to get as big and hard as he could...

FACE THE MUSIC

“S hoot,” he sighed, blasted with the cold wind, turning and grabbing his coat which he’d abandoned behind the driver’s seat a couple hours ago because he had the heat in the cab so high. Lunch tote over a shoulder, thermos in one hand and his coat bundled under a forearm, he hustled up the driveway with his head down, marching over the path and onto the porch, stomping his boots.

One of the best things about being on the road so long was coming home. It was a weird thing, but absence really did make the heart grow fonder. Now he looked inside, saw his happy home, knew he’d soon be warm and Janie would be waiting for him. Only when he went around the porch to the mudroom, shoulders hunched up high, pushed the door open, it was like the place was empty. No sound, no lights, no smell of food cooking. For a moment he thought maybe she’d gone out—but both trucks were in the driveway. Maybe they went snowmobiling.

He tossed his coat onto the bench, too tired to hang it up. With a knee down on the bench’s arm, he leaned his shoulder on the wall for a moment, feeling like he would pass out. When he got his breath, he pushed himself off, stumbled into the kitchen, found it empty. *Where the heck were they?*

Sheba yawned, and he said to her, “Yeah, you’re probably right, probably painting.” He hadn’t looked in the windows of the addition as he’d come around the corner because the wind was too fierce.

He opened the fridge, brought out a pint of half-and-half, poured himself a juice glass and knocked it back, hoping it might quench the fire that was simmering in his stomach right now. There were no kitchen smells. No Janie home smells. Nothing was cooking, nothing in the oven. The

Findlay was on, just producing ambient heat. He opened the oven door and saw nothing in there. The stovetop was cool. Most strange, the sink was full of dishes. A pan someone had scrambled eggs and not scraped clean, not even washed, just sitting loose in the dirty sink with glasses and plates and a cutting board with dried crescents of mushroom remnants. She must've really got wrapped up in painting.

He poured himself another shot of the half-and-half, knocked it back, dashed some clean water into the glass and dropped it in the sink with the rest of the stuff that needed to be done. Wasn't like Janie at all...

He started to worry something had happened today. A strange worming fear crawled up his back that it was Marissa. Something terrible. A phone call. Janie was too distraught to drive and Roxie had to come and pick her up. Were there tracks in the driveway before he'd plowed it?—he couldn't even remember...

Now he went to the addition and yanked open the door. It was warm and bright, no lights were on but Maceo was there. His back was to him, the kid leaning on a table with his hands curled over the lip while he faced the easels. There was a painting on each; Maceo's a mostly blank canvas, and on Janie's, her newest piece: a bright blue sky painted on a square canvas. His sweet woman not so grim these days.

Before he'd opened his mouth to get the kid's attention, feet thundered down the steps behind him from the second floor. Sheba whirled and trotted to greet Janie. His wife thumped down on the hardwood, skipping the last step and dipping to pet Sheeb's head. She looked up, saw him, and her face went bright.

"John! You're home," she smiled warmly and honestly and skipped to him. "I'm so glad you're home..."

In the second before they embraced he had a strange flash of thought; the weird phrasing of her sentence, its almost theatrical exposition, her exuberance and need to come to him...

But her desire to see him was real, because she jumped into his arms just like Marissa had done before he'd left to deal with this storm, and her grip around his neck was honest. He held her lean and light body, felt her movements under the light sweater and hugged her tight.

"Oh, I'm so glad you're home," she whispered again.

He breathed her in, smelled her sweat. The way she'd come down made him think she'd just cleaned up...

“You been painting all day?” he said, his voice a little high and dry and croaky. Curiosity, worry, and thirty hours straight without sleep or talking.

“Yes, we were. I slept in, we had a late lunch... we’ve been painting ever since. John... oh shoot, you’re hungry. Let me get you something to eat...”

“It’s okay,” he lied. “It’s okay, I ate at the Dunkin’.”

“John, don’t do that,” she scolded, took his hand led him toward the kitchen.

Maceo watched from the worktable, still leaning against it, turned away three-quarters and looking over a shoulder but nodding his chin and smiling.

“Hey, Maceo,” he said, gave a small wave.

“Hi, John,” he said, smiled and waved back.

Janie pulled him into the kitchen. “Come on, John, I’ll get you something to eat. I didn’t make anything, but there are lots of leftovers. What do you want? I can make anything...”

“You’re not wearing your painting clothes,” he said.

“We just finished, I changed already,” she said, “I knew you’d be home soon, and I was going to start cooking...”

“You had fun?”

She brought both hands onto the counter. “John,” she said, looking at him steadily, “I had the best day today.”

“Your new painting looks a lot brighter.”

She laughed. “Doesn’t it?” She turned now, opened the fridge, began pulling out covered casserole dishes. She said, “Let me heat you up some beef... there’s roasted potatoes here, too...”

His stomach had tightened. He *was* hungry, but he didn’t feel like eating. Right now, all he wanted to do was sleep. “Look at your cheeks, Janie. What the heck have you been doing?”

She put her hands over her cheeks, eyes wide and glistening with wet. “What’s wrong with my cheeks?”

“They’re bright red. You look so happy.”

Her brow had taken a small tent of worry but it loosened now and she smiled. “Thank you,” she said.

“Why don’t you keep painting or something. I just want to hit the hay. I’ll eat when I get up, let me just get like four, five hours first.”

“You’ll have dinner with us?”

“Absolutely,” he said. “Don’t heat up anything now, I have heartburn.”
She said okay and told him to go on up to bed.

As Janie closed the fridge door he moved around the island and slipped an arm around her waist, pulled her against him. He said, “I’m glad you had fun today.” He didn’t mean it in a bad way at all and hoped she knew that.

“I painted all day,” she said, “I feel *so* good...”

“Good for you, kid,” he said, kissed her cheek. “Look at that color...”
He admired her pretty face. “I like seeing you like this...”

“This again,” she said with a smirk.

“Yeah,” he agreed, giving her his own sly but tired smile. “Looks like this again.”

“Go on up to bed,” she said, “go get ready, I’ll be up in a minute.”

“Going to tuck me in?”

“Don’t you worry what I’m going to do,” she said.

“All right,” he said, not sure exactly what that meant, but thinking that he liked it. “See you up there,” he said, and trudged up stairs.

In the bedroom, he took off his stinky shirt, looked in the bathroom and considered having a shower. He stunk. Sheba slipped in the bedroom as he was taking his jeans off.

He told her: “I’m about to close that door, Sheeb—if you want to go lay by the fire, go do it... You don’t want to hang out with me *all* the time, now do you?” She yawned, looked around as if she understood, dipped her head, turned around and left.

Now he regretted it, wishing she stayed so he could put his arm around her when he fell asleep. He tossed his jeans on the chair where Janie kept her painting clothes, then realized he should hang them on a hook instead of draping his dirty things overtop of his wife’s. She was probably going to go paint again while he was sleeping.

When he pulled his pants away, he saw Janie’s jeans tossed haphazardly on the seat of the chair. A pair of faded old Levi’s that she’d had forever. One leg folded up, zipper undone, one half of the fly folded over in a frayed triangle. He hung his pants on a hook using the belt still wound through the loops, his eyes still on Janie’s jeans. He picked them up, shook them out.

There was a spreading denim darkness through the crotch. He frowned, clenched the inside of one cheek between his teeth, studying it. The mark spread up the fly, and down both thighs, almost imperceptibly darker, but if you held the fabric out the way he was doing you could see a ragged

circular darkness. He gripped the crotch in his right hand and imagined they were a warmish damp. Held up to his nose, he recognized a familiar scent. Janie's scent. His cheek began to ache—his molars had clamped down too hard on his cheek flesh. His brow had scrunched down low, too, and he opened his mouth and exhaled slowly. He set the jeans down and tried to arrange them the way he'd found them.

He sat on the bed, a very precise and sharp thought being pushed away and spread into oblivion because he didn't want to deal with it. Instead, he stared dumbly at the floor, looking at the pattern of the oval cotton rug on the hardwood. He wanted to focus on it, wanted to think what the jeans meant, but his higher mind knew that that would be a bad thing to do. It was like he'd been struck in the head with a heavy object and left dumbfounded. He fell back on the mattress, pushed himself up with his heels and elbows until his head was on his pillow, covered himself up with blankets and staring at the cedar strip ceiling. Before this envelope of dread opened itself and he could see the contents that would horrify him forever, footsteps came quick up the stairs now. He chewed the inside of his cheek again, head turning on the pillow and watching the bedroom door.

It opened, his wife backing in, closing the door quietly behind her again. Under one arm, she had a long scroll of paper tied with a piece of twine.

"What are you doing?" he asked.

"I told you to come up and wait for me..."

"This my surprise?"

"Yes," she said, breathy and excited. "This is your surprise." She jumped on the bed onto her knees like teenage Janie with a juicy gossip gem, saying, "Okay, sit up, sit up..."

With one hand, she scrolled up the loop of twine until it fell off the end of the rolled paper. "Okay, okay, you ready?..."

Jane was bright and bubbling, looking so young and impressionable, so unlike his normally levelheaded wife. This was Janie. The unsure one, the hopeful one. Now he was smiling. "What is it?"

"What did you ask me?"

"What do you mean?"

"John, come on," she said, looking exasperated and slumping. "The thing..."

"What's the thing?"

"You wanted something..."

He said, "Is that a drawing?"

"It's not a blank piece of paper, John."

He laughed. "You're a real jerk today, Janie."

She laughed, too, ran her hand over her bright red cheeks, and pulled her hair away from her face. "I'm not being a jerk."

"You're just excited."

She nodded, sniffed, smoothed her hair.

He asked: "Did you pose for him?" There was a hesitation and grim worry in his voice he hadn't intended, but he supposed it emerged honestly.

She nodded. "You ready?..."

Now he *was* ready. "Sure." His stomach burned like he'd swallowed a hot lead ball, and worry had tightened up his breathing—but right now he wanted to see what was on that piece of paper.

"Are you sure you're ready?..."

"Janie, come on..."

"Okay, all right," she said, both of them excited now. She set the rolled paper down, pulled her hair back from her face again, saying, "Wish I had a tie..."

"Janie, would you please just show me the drawing..."

"You look," she said, nodding her chin toward the loosely rolled sheet of paper.

He reached for it, realized his hands had gone sweaty, dried them on his thighs. He was licking at his upper lip, frowning, hands moving with trepidation as though afraid the paper would be hot to the touch.

It was cool and dry, and the paper rattled from his shaking as he unrolled it. One hand at the top, he pulled down at the bottom like he was looking at an ancient map. There, done in shades of gray, was the most beautiful picture he'd ever seen. Everything stopped, and he looked into those eyes rendered by the hand of another man. His wife's eyes. His wife's eyes as Maceo had seen them. This was his girlfriend Janie posing for another man. This was how she looked at him. This was how Maceo saw her... he saw the *real* Janie. Or at least a tender part of her that John remembered from so long ago.

He opened his mouth to speak, but felt a strange tightness in his chest and he was sure that if he uttered a word, it would be choked off with a sob. He closed his mouth again.

"What do you think?"

He sniffed wetly, his eyes swelled in their sockets. He looked at the bare curve of her beautiful thin shoulder, recognized the flannel shirt she wore when she painted—one that he'd worn for years before she'd swiped it for herself. It had fallen low off the shoulder, exposing it; low, very low. Maceo had rendered that soft flesh of her breast just above her nipple. The light was from the right side, and he imagined her standing in the windows he'd framed himself while a young Italian man worked at his easel.

She prompted him again: "Do you like it?"

His mouth opened again, but his jaw was trembling. He closed his mouth, bit his lower lip.

"John, do you like it?" Her voice was more urgent.

Looking in those drawn eyes had him locked. He was frozen, mind whirling with awful feelings, twisting in knots with good feelings. The happy ones, seeing his wife the way he used to know her, the bad ones, knowing it was another man who saw it now. He let the two ends of the paper come together because they wanted to close. Something so beautiful couldn't be looked at for long. He would overload.

The paper made a dry crinkling sound and young Janie was gone. He sniffed wetly, and Janie took the drawing out of his hands.

When he looked at her, he had to blink away tears that suddenly swelled. He laughed. "Wow," he said.

"It's amazing, isn't it?"

"It was more than I can even... it's more than... Let me see it again..."

She sat back on her heels and scrolled the paper open, holding it for him. The light outside their windows was bright and blue, and he saw everything Maceo had done. Saw the light he put on Janie's face to bring out her sparkle. Now something inside him snapped, just a tiny thread, but he could practically hear the pinging as it gave way under tension.

Maceo saw her most secret and beautiful self and wanted it.

He put his hand over his heart, said, "It's the most beautiful piece of art I've ever seen."

"Well, thanks, John," she said cynically, making a funny face.

He looked at her seriously. "Janie, I love *everything* you do. It's not that..."

"You just like the subject matter..."

"Exactly," he said quietly, looking into the drawing of his wife's eyes.

She let it close again, leaned back and rested it on the night table, leaving it pinned behind the lamp. When she turned back, there was a new look on her face. It was serious. She crawled over top of him, and he took her in his arms, big hands going up her slim sides, feeling the points of her shoulder blades, gripping that silky blonde hair as their mouths came together.

He locked his on hers, kissed her deeply, passionately, his body flooded with instant, depthless pleasure. Pure love flooded out from his heart like water squished from a sponge. He squeezed her tight and Janie threw a leg over his hips and straddled him now. She sat up, her legs astride him like she was riding a horse. Her cheeks were red, her eyes bright; she breathed heavily through her mouth.

She pulled off her sweater. She wore a NKOTB concert T-shirt. Metropolitan Club, Buffalo, 1994. Face The Music Tour. She and her girlfriends had snuck off to the city without permission. Her mom and dad shit. He laughed. She hadn't worn it in more than a decade. Bought it when she was fourteen and it still fit. She took it off. She wore no bra. He put his hands over her breasts and she fell against him again.

Then things were moving fast; they were snorting from their noses, shoving tongues in their mouths, hugging, touching grasping, pushing down their pants, getting naked.

"Yes, John, yes, I need you so bad," she said, reaching behind her, grabbing his steely hard-on, and he wanted her to be proud of it, as proud as he was, because right now he felt like he was nineteen again. "On top like this?"

She didn't even answer, aiming his tip into her seam, holding him underhanded, wiggling her hips and letting him sink all the way inside her. It was like pushing into butter. Janie was sopping. Her juices spilled through his pubic hair and he thought of the stain on her jeans and groaned from awful psychic pain. A fluttering heart-crush was sweet and fun, but Janie's sex had lubricated when she was with Maceo...

She hissed and groaned, her head tossing forward, hair slashing across his neck and one sensitive nipple. He grabbed her neck; she bit her lip and closed her eyes, clutched her fingernails deep into his arm and began swiveling her hips. He pushed her further away so he could look at her face because he'd never seen her like this before. Closed off, getting something,

her mind focusing on a distant point is if she were trying to bend a spoon in some CIA back room.

“Fuck, Janie,” he cursed, startled by his profane word but it was so damn fitting right now. This was profound and crazy, wild, pushing his heart rate up high. He flexed his ass pumped himself against her, and she squeezed him between her thighs, chewing on her lower lip, eyes squinted shut, making soft little groaning sounds.

Her hips swiveled faster and faster, she began pumping up and down as well, bouncing on him.

“God, Janie, my God, do it...”

His hands went down her body, grabbed her ass, began shoving her hips down as he thrust upward. He watched her breasts shake and bounce, collide together, jiggle, her nipples dancing around in circles as she did everything to pleasure herself on his grandest erection in a decade.

“Get it, Janie, get it,” he grunted. “You’re so hot, I fucking love you...”

She squeaked and grunted but could speak no words. Her breasts continued to dance, that red flush spread from her cheeks and across her shoulders, broadcasting across the bare flesh of her breasts. Her mouth fell open, and she panted soft feminine sounds...

CHALLENGES

The headboard banged the wall in an ascending, building crescendo. The bed creaked, rattled, and groaned under their intense humping and thrashing. The points of her knees burned against the cotton sheets, and the inside of her thighs were shredded by John's hairy legs. But she was *so* fucking close.

Nails running on her husband's chest, eyes shut and closed, she panted, grunted, feeling some intense interior pressure pushing outward, fighting the tightest of confines, ready to burst her seams and explode.

She chanted, "Oh God, oh God, oh God..."

Her eyes fluttered open, hands slicking across John's matted chest. Both of them sweated; a droplet fell from her nose and melted along John's collar.

John watched her, eyes boring into hers. There was an expression of horror, or of shock. Mouth hung open, eyes wide—she knew what he was seeing. Knew he was seeing something he'd never witnessed. Knew it because she'd never felt like this before. "Oh John, oh John, it's coming, it's coming..."

"Come, Janie, come..."

Her eyes snapped shut again, her head whipped forward; she snorted and inhaled through her nose, sunk her nails into John's neck. In her mind's eye, she saw Maceo. Saw his face resting in the pillows as she rode atop him. Dancing in his lap, that big dick he had goring her deep, deeper than she'd ever had it, pushing apart her innermost self, his young, hard cock doing things to her she'd never felt before.

“Oh God, oh God,” she panted, faster and faster, “it’s coming, John, it’s coming...”

John clutched her breasts, and it shot her head back, eyes still shut, but seeing a bright sunburst glow blood-red against her closed off lids. She cried out, cried out loud and huge as the orgasm swelled up over her floodgates, washed over the top in a tidal wave, cascading the other side and destroying the innocent villages below. She babbled, cried out long again, choked it off; squeezed the cry into a narrow groan; her hips tightened, her pelvis pushed forward so she could have her husband as deep as he would go. John had nothing to be ashamed about, at least she didn’t think so, he had a magnificent dick—right now, though, she was thinking what it would be like to have Maceo inside her. She held her breath, snorted through her nose, choked in a hoarse breath and collapsed forward as John’s arms embraced around her tight, almost crushing her. His hips thrust up hard and fast, and she could feel his testicles slapping at her bottom. He grunted like an animal, said dirty words, not stringing them together in a cohesive thought but just in a profane, base babble.

“John, oh John,” she whispered.

Then he came too. Both of them shooting up into the stratosphere this afternoon like a couple of middle-aged rockets. Full blast, no ballast, they left the Earth’s atmosphere with surprising ease.

“Janie, oh fuck,” he said, arms tightening, squeezing the breath out of her lungs.

He pushed deeper, and she squeezed him with all her might, rolling her pelvis forward and back, milking whatever he had out of him. It went on and on like that, both of their pleasure being wrung out like a dirty dishtowel they’d been using too long. It left them both panting, desperate for breath, slick with sweat and enervated. She collapsed fully on him, her body loosening to the strength of gelatin and John’s arms slipping off and falling heavily to the bed on either side of her.

“Oh John, oh my God,” she breathed out.

“Janie, oh Janie, oh wow,” he said.

Moving her hand up to cup his beard took a lot of effort, but when it was there, she caressed him with her thumb, running the cushion over his lower lip. “I love you so much, John.”

“I love you, too,” he exhaled, barely able to talk.

She rode up and down on his big burly body, riding it like a raft lost at sea. “Okay,” she sighed, “too hot,” then pushing off him, collapsing naked on the bed and pulling up sheets to cover her naked self. She could feel his seed slipping out of her. She said, “The sheets definitely need to be washed now...”

John chuckled and groaned, shaking the bed, covered his face with a big hand, brushed his hair back. With his elbow up and his hairy armpit exposed, he said, “I stink.”

She said, “You *do* stink.”

“Sorry.”

Now she chuckled. “I love your stink.”

“Yeah, you better.”

She sighed out a long breath that turned to a whistle. “That was intense.”

“I love you so much, Jane.”

With the back of her wrist she batted his hip, blinking and looking up at the ceiling. “I love you too, John.”

“That was something, I tell you, I—”

A door closed near them. She sat up on her elbows. Maceo was in the bathroom. Now she heard the taps opening full blast behind the headboard. He was running a shower.

John laughed. “You think he heard us?”

“Oh my God. I hope not.”

He said, “I hope so. Then he’ll know how much I love that drawing.”

She regarded him, looking worn but happy, bags under his eyes shielded by the hand curled on his forehead. She said, “That really does it for you...”

He let his hand fall heavily down to the mattress again, turned his head in the pillow to look at her. “It’s you that does it for me, Janie.”

They looked at each other for a long while, staring into each other’s eyes in the late afternoon sun streaming between the curtains. Her husband no longer looked like the young guy she knew when they were teens, but they had been together, completely together, for so long. There was no one in her life like him. Had a big beard now, that young chiseled frame with his hard chest and his round biceps had bulked up to that of a forty-year-old man. And she loved him. Loved him deeply. There was no doubt about it.

She leaned forward, kissed his hairy shoulder. She said, “Sleep now, sleep now, John. Come have dinner with us when you wake up.”

“I will.”

She made a comical sniffing sound, performing for him. “But have a shower first.”

He laughed, and as she backed off the bed he reached out and hooked his hand around the small of her back. He pulled her so she collapsed on him and got her giggling. They kissed, she looked in his eyes, her forearms resting on him.

The things she was doing were terrible. They had to stop. Enough was enough.

Her smile faltered. “Okay, baby,” she whispered, kissing his bearded chin and slinking backward. “Get some shut eye, I’ll make you something you like.”

He held her hand until their arms both stretched out straight, pinched her fingers with his before letting her go. She gathered her clothing, slipped into the bathroom and dressed. She brushed her teeth, washed her face, used some toilet paper to clean up between her legs. When she tiptoed out of the bedroom, John was already asleep.

Sheba was sleeping in the sewing room and she held the door for her to go and join John in bed so he wasn’t alone.



In the kitchen, she poured herself a tall glass of water from the tap and drank it. When it was empty, she filled it a quarter of the way and drank that too, then set the hard glass down on the counter with a thunk. She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and looked out at the snowy landscape.

It had to stop. It wasn’t acceptable, and it wasn’t innocent, Janie, even if he didn’t put his penis inside you.

She wouldn’t ask Maceo to leave, but she had to be realistic. Painting *only* from now on. No more morning visits. No more wake ups and climbing into his bed so they could use their hands on each other. That was crazy.

A chime resounded behind her. She turned to see Maceo’s phone face up on the dining room table. The pipes had stopped their rumble from the

bathroom overhead, but he was still in his room. Why'd he want to have a shower *now*?

She filled the kettle, pushed down the lever to get it boiling. With her arms folded, she made her way around the chimney, circling near Maceo's phone that had returned to blank and black again. She went full circle around the chimney, opened the cookstove and added some more split kindling. She didn't know what she would cook yet, but she knew it would be red meat. Her husband needed to replenish. She was feeling kind of hungry herself, too.

Maceo's phone chimed again. Now she was quick stepping, arms folded casually, coming near the dining room table and leaning forward at the waist to read the screen. There were a string of texts, but she read the last one.

Mar: on the main street. It's clean and quiet. Nice place

Mar? Mar was texting with Maceo?

She pressed the phone's home button, and the screen lit up again but now there was nothing to read, just a picture of Maceo with his mother and father and sisters. She let it fade to black. Now she was pinching a bulb of inner cheek flesh with the points of her canines, lips pouted out.

There was movement upstairs, Evan's bedroom door opening and closing, and then the sound of feet on stairs. She hustled herself back into the kitchen and arranged her teapot, stood with arms still folded and waited for the grumbling kettle to boil.

When Maceo came down, he said, "It's okay if I go out?"

She repeated, "Go out?"

"Yes. Some people from school."

"Rochester?"

"No, they come through, want to meet."

She frowned, studied his face. She didn't like this sudden relationship. Asking her for permission like she was his mother. An hour ago his penis was in her mouth. She shrugged. "You don't want dinner?"

"I eat out."

"Yeah. You can do whatever. Who is it you're meeting?"

"Some people I know from Chesborough."

“Why are they coming through Iroquois Falls?” she said as the lever on the boiling kettle snapped up.

“They go to Buffalo.”

“And they pass this way?”

“They say come meet them, we get dinner.”

“Yeah,” she said quietly. “You like to eat.”

She filled her teapot and put the lid on top, ceramic rattling because her hand was shaking. “Yeah, okay, when are you going to go?” She turned and leaned on the counter.

He said, “I head out now. They text me from the road.”

“Okay. Take the Yukon. You know your way to Iroquois Falls?”

“I do,” he said. “I go through every day.”

“I thought you bypassed it down the Phelps Road. Okay. You know where you’re going in the town?”

“I do,” he said, heading into the mudroom.

Still chewing her cheek, she stared at the woodstove and listened to him put on a coat, keys jingling.

When he returned, he said, “John like his drawing?”

“I showed him,” she said. “He *more* than liked it.”

That made Maceo beam. He clapped his hands together softly once before then turning up the collar of his jacket and thrusting them in his pockets. “It make me so happy,” he said.

“He really... he *loved* it, Maceo,” she said morosely.

“Okay,” he said, “I be back in a few hours.”

“Have fun,” she said. Not moving, not smiling.

Maceo stepped out the front door, and she watched him with his shoulders hunched up walking through the cold along the wraparound porch and then down to the driveway.

First thing she did when he was out of sight was go find her phone. It’d been left in the studio, and she was in there now standing near the woodstove and warming the backs of her legs. She texted.

Jane: what are you doing tonight?

Now she waited, phone clutched over her stomach, heat licking up the backs of her legs and over her bottom. After a while her phone dinged.

Mar: studying. What's up?

Jane: Where are you?

Mar: Why?

Jane: You're at school?

Mar: yup, I'm in my dorm room.

Jane: Okay, how's it going?

Mar: Good, big test on Monday gotta be prepared

Jane: always be prepared

Mar: u taught me well

She returned to the kitchen, set the phone down, poured herself a cup of tea and dragged a stool to sit by the counter.

Was Mar really in her dorm room? And if she was lying, *why* was she lying? Because she was hooking up with Maceo and didn't want her mother to know? Of course Mar wouldn't tell her. She would be furious.

She sipped her tea, still chewing on her cheek until it hurt. She picked up her phone, dialed, this time with a video call. *You lying to me, sweetheart?*

She waited, wondering how Mar would explain why she wouldn't pick up a video call. *Oh, I didn't hear, Mom, sorry...*

But Mar picked up. Now she was looking at her daughter, obviously laying in her bed. She recognized the bed sheets. They picked them out together at Costco. White with a pale pink flower pattern. Mar had her head in the pillow, blonde hair spread out around her in a mess. She looked tired.

Mar said, "Is everything okay?"

"Yeah," she said, "why?"

"You're being weird."

“I just miss you,” she said—which wasn’t a lie.

“I miss you too. I can come home again next weekend.”

“You don’t have to. No, stay at school.”

“How’s Dad?”

“He’s very good. Very, very good. He’s asleep right now.”

“He survived the storm?”

“He whipped it into shape, Mar.”

“That’s my daddy,” she said, then rolled to her side and propped her cheek in the cup of her palm.

She said, “You look tired, baby.”

“Study, study, study. How’s Maceo?”

She bristled but hid it. “He’s fine.”

“That’s good. He go out?”

“Yeah, he’s meeting some friends.”

Mar asked, “What are *you* doing tonight?”

“I think I’m going to make your dad a big dinner for when he wakes up. He deserves a feast.”

“Okay. Make daddy his favorite.” She sighed then, looked sleepy, smiled. “I gotta study.”

“What’s your test?”

“Biology.”

“You be good,” she said.

“Tell Daddy I said hi.”

“I will. I love you.”

“I love you too, Mom.”

They closed the call. *So it was friends from school.* She sipped her tea again, scalding the top curl of her lip. She soothed it with the point of her tongue. *Were they girls?* A couple girls maybe out from California and studying at Chesborough, ‘passing through’ snowy old Iroquois Falls as a pretense to hook up with that tall, good-looking Italian guy in their art class?

She turned down the baffle on the wood stove, set it to 350, stood upright, and worried her thumb over her sore painting knuckles. Then she turned the oven down to zero.

In the mudroom, she donned a barn coat and her slip-on boots. She grabbed the keys to the pickup, went outside and around the porch. The

absence of the Yukon was striking. It made her feel even more alone. She got in the pickup, closed the door but sat with her keys in her hand.

What are you doing, Janie? You're going to go to Iroquois Falls? And do what? Spy on him? That would be a really neat thing to do. Wouldn't it be great if he caught you driving by, your pale face in the driver-side window watching to see what he was doing? What a loser.

"Crap," she said, thumped her fist on the steering wheel.

And who cares? He was twenty. He was going to have twenty-year-old friends. Don't get crazy. Just paint with him. It doesn't have to be more than that. You're married, you know? You know that man up in your bed right now, the one you love?...

"I really do love you, John," she whispered.

She pushed the pickup door open with her foot, stepped back onto the driveway, returned to the house.

BABIES

Janie's graphite eyes stared down on him from the fireplace mantle at the foot of the bed when he awoke. The drawing Maceo had done was held top and bottom with five-inch spring clamps to a thin, wooden board. It was on show now next to the pastel drawing he'd done earlier. This graphite one was more pointed. In comparison with the previous drawing he could see leaps and bounds of improvement. An improved connection. He was closer to his subject. But, of course, they'd claimed Janie hadn't posed for the first one. She said she posed for the charcoal one.

Maceo captured a sparkle in her eye. Now, it wasn't like she had lost it, that she was no longer that happy girl she once was; her eyes sparkled plenty. Just not in the same way.

There was an almost hesitant tug to that simple drawn smile, too. A familiar slight shifting to one side like she was thinking something and didn't want you to know about it. But whatever secret it was, it made her smile. The fact that Maceo had drawn it bothered him in a strange sort of way. Jealousy? Yeah, for sure. But there was a time when he himself made a few girls go watery in the knees. Those days were gone. And it was more than jealousy. There was an ache inside him from that expression on her face. How did Maceo know it? Because now he was convinced he knew what it was.

There was a narrow window of time when they were carefree. A narrow window of time when that look on her face meant something huge. He'd seen that look before. And that look got her pregnant.

He ran his lower row of teeth in a sawing motion over his upper lip and tried clenching straggling hairs from his mustache. God, that face. Just look

at it. When he was seventeen-years-old he would've done anything for her. But now that he was thirty-nine, almost forty, wouldn't he still do anything for her? Absolutely.

What was different?

He just longed for that time. They'd thought their greatest concerns were homework and math tests. All they ever wanted to do was spend time together. Hold hands and kiss and duck into secret places where they could stick their hands in each other's pants. Then they took it too far.

"Oh man," he sighed, chuckling a little, putting his hand down over top of the quilt and feeling his hardness humping below it. This was turning into one wild ride. Maceo entering their lives had roused something in him despite the jealous spike in his heart. Something wild that maybe sometimes he wished wasn't in him, and yet other times he cherished. Because love hurt. You just had to listen to the radio, which he did sitting in his truck sometimes forty hours at a clip. And, boy, did love hurt. But it was in the best way possible.

He rolled over to see Janie's back to him, that fresh new hairdo tangled and spread out on her pillow. She had a narrow back, slender and graceful, and if she wasn't wearing a shirt, he knew he would see the way her muscle held her shoulder blades, maybe could see the corrugated sheet of her ribs. She was way too beautiful. And he was the luckiest guy he knew. Coming home yesterday had been astounding. Unexpected. Saturday morning was just the same—getting it on with her like they were a couple of teenagers in their pantry. First thing this morning and look at him—hard again.

But while they made a serious connection after his shift yesterday afternoon, banged their brains out on this bed and he'd had an orgasm so fierce he'd lost vision in one eye for a few seconds (didn't lose it, it had just gone white), and it had felt like his head was going to explode. When he woke up though, he'd showered, scrubbed away all that stink he'd collected sitting in his truck for that long, changed the bed sheets. Being a good boy for his good wife. With the new ones on, he bundled up the old semen- and sweat-stained ones, brought them down to the laundry and threw them in the basket. The kitchen was filled with the smell of food. Beef, onions, something fried, maybe her home cut potato wedges. And sure enough, it was. But something had changed.

They'd ate dinner together, and they had a great time, a sweet talk. He'd held her hand. But despite the bounty of emotion he'd come home to and

the physical manifestation of it, Janie seemed gloomy. Maceo was out so it was just the two of them sitting alone at the dining room table. He said what the hell and offered up wine. They both had a glass instead of his usual Budweiser. Very sophisticated. She was smiling, loving. But something troubled her. He tried watching TV, curling up on the couch with her, but he was asleep in about an hour, totally exhausted and totally stuffed. She'd woke him by pinching his toes and squeezing his knees. *Go to bed*, she'd told him, and he did.

He slipped out of bed now, trying to be quiet. Sheba lay on the cotton rug on the far side. Her tags jingled as she rose with him, and he held a finger up to his mouth to shush her like she would understand. He slipped on jeans and a flannel. He tiptoed around Janie's side of the bed and found her awake, laying on her side, two hands in the attitude of prayer tucked under one cheek. Her eyes were open and blinking.

"Hey," he said, "I've been trying to be quiet."

"Good morning," she said, her voice hoarse.

He sat on the edge of the bed and squeezed her shoulder. "You feeling all right?"

"Okay," she said.

"You look tired..."

She nodded, and he brushed the backs of his fingers over her cheek. She kissed his hand.

"Hey," he said, "I'm going in to the depot this morning. Okay?"

"Okay," she said.

"But I'll be home early. All right? Just a bunch of maintenance, you know how it goes. We'll all have dinner tonight. Maybe we'll watch some TV, maybe... Hey, you want to go out and do something? We can bring Maceo..."

She nodded and sucked on her lower lip.

"You sure you're feeling okay?"

She said, "Maybe I'm coming down with something."

"Stay in bed. I'll do the chores."

"Let Maceo do them," she said.

"He can do them?"

She nodded again.

"Tell him to run a shovel around the place too then."

It provoked a slight smile. He kissed the corner of it, caressed her hair.

When he pulled back, she said, “John...”

“Yeah?”

“I love you.”

His heart just about swelled too big for his chest; he put his lips against hers, inhaled her deeply, kissed her mouth, the tip of her nose, and her warm forehead. “I love you too.”

Then he was up, clapping his hands, getting Sheba excited. He smiled as he closed the door and left her laying in bed. Maceo was backing out of Evan’s bedroom, dressed for school.

“Hey, Maceo, look at you. Up early.”

He said, “Yes, I go early to paint.”

“Working on something at the school?”

“I am. With some others.” And as if suddenly realizing the early time, assured: “Don’t worry, I do the chores.”

“You can do ‘em, or I can. If you gotta go, just let me know. I’m heading in to work soon, but...”

“No, don’t worry. I do them. I want to do them.”

“All right, come on down to the kitchen, let’s get some coffee happening...”



With the paper shopper between her boots, she sat in the medical center’s waiting office pretending to read a Cosmo from 2012. The mouth of the bag tufted static paper flames in pale pink tissue. She was at the Kingston Family Medicine Clinic, fifteen minutes south from home in the small burg of Corfu just off the Thruway. No appointment, she wasn’t here on official business. *Not really.*

There were a dozen people in the waiting room, some old, some infirm, and some healthy-looking teenagers. Young kids too, playing with a collection of brightly colored plastic toys in the corner where a small LCD screen showed an episode of SpongeBob SquarePants. Dr. Bernard’s clinic was in a long, low, metal-sided building supporting two doctors (her and Michael Weiner, which they laughed their asses off when she brought him on almost a decade ago), and two nurse practitioners.

Patricia was working reception and now came close with her clipboard tucked at her side. She put her hand on Jane's shoulder, said in a whisper, "Stacy's got fifteen if you want to duck in now."

She thanked her quietly, collected the shopper and went around the reception counter to the exam rooms. She knew the way, didn't need to be escorted, went into exam room 1, but instead of sitting in the chrome-leg seat opposite the doctor's swivel chair, she hopped up on the padded exam table.

It was another ten minutes before Stacy showed up. Her stomach had twisted itself into a tight ball, but when she saw her friend and long ago baby-buddy, she smiled, waved with both hands, the paper shopper balanced in her lap.

"Hey, hey, baby," she said as they came together and hugged. She smoothed her hand over Stacy's back.

When they parted, Stacy asked, "How's it been going?"

"It's going great," she said.

"Things aren't getting lonely?"

"I've seen Mar a lot in the last month for a girl who's supposed to be away at school."

Stacy leaned against the counter, took her stethoscope off and rested it behind her. "How's Maceo?"

"He's fitting in," she said, that knot in her stomach tightening. "He's doing really well. He loves school..."

"Is he happy with that professor he came all the way to see? What's her name...?"

The dread-knot tightened further, and she was chewing on that sore spot on the inside of her cheek again. "I don't know. I mean, yes, he's met her. He's very happy, I think. He doesn't talk about her that much." *Maybe he just met with her for a dirty rendezvous in an Iroquois Falls tavern recommended by Marissa.*

Because she could feel her expression revealing way too much, she forced herself to brighten. She hooked an index finger under each of the twine hoops of the shopping bag and hoisted it from her lap, saying, "I come bearing gifts..."

Stacy closed the distance again, head tilting with affection, saying, "You're the best. You really are just the best, Janie. This is for April?"

"Yep. Booties, cap, even did a onesie. How's the pregnancy coming?"

“Girl’s fit as a fiddle, and that baby is getting bigger every day—you should see the size of her belly now.”

A delighted groan dragged from her, and she draped a hand over her own stomach. “Oh my God. I can’t wait to see her.”

Stacy beamed. “We’re going to have a young one around again.”

They gossiped for about five minutes. Talked about the kids, talked about the weather, the new grocery store opening in Basom; she shared the recipe for the mac & cheese mini casseroles she served at Maceo’s party, writing it down with a pen on the back of a pamphlet on diabetes. But when it came time for Stacy to get back to work, her hands were sweating and she just about chickened out. As her longtime friend hooped the stethoscope back around her neck, she said, “Hey, do you think I could get in to see Lexus today?”

“Nurse practitioner? What do you need?”

“I just wanted something simple. Didn’t want to bother you.”

“Bother me? What are you, crazy?” She came back, put both hands in the middle of her thighs and squeezed them.

Their faces were very close, and there was no more stalling. She rolled her eyes, said, “I was wondering about... I was wondering about getting an IUD.”

Stacy laughed, frowned, stepped back and folded her arms. “No big deal, Janie. Sure. You know what, we’ll get Lexus to do it right now.”

Then they were both silent, and the fact that she had nothing to say set Stacy’s brain in motion.

Now she wished she had just kept the conversation moving, shuffled a little two-step exit stage right and off to the nurse practitioner. But here she watched as a good friend—who wasn’t John’s doctor—began to ponder why Janie would need an IUD.

Stacy’s expression slowly faded. She said, “Okay. Yeah, all right,” and turned around, gave Janie her back and rested her hands on the counter. She ran water in the sink, washed her hands, and rubbed her eyes. When she returned, her cheeks had gone red. She said, “There’s a bunch of different ways you can go, but we’ve known each other a long time...” She paused to let it hang, let the meaning settle redolent in the air. “I think I know what you would want. Go with the OvoGard. I’ll set it up...” She looked suddenly tired. “I’ll let Lexus know. It’s got fewer chemicals. Uh, hormone-

free. Copper as extra spermicide.” She folded her arms, and they stared each other again.

Janie said, “It’s not what you’re thinking.”

Stacy squished her mouth to one side, frowned, looked to the side, eyes settling on the paper shopper filled with the baby things she’d knitted. “Okay. I don’t even know what to say.”

Her friend Stacy obviously remembered the two days John had spent at home with a bag of ice on his testicles after his vasectomy and watched every Die Hard movie in succession. Her husband made a big deal out of it, that loudmouth, let everybody know he was treating it like a vacation. He drank dozens of beers even though she told him he wasn’t supposed to. Even Stacy had told him not to drink so many beers when he was on those pills.

“Don’t worry about me,” Janie said.

“I don’t know what to say here. Because I’m your doctor, I mean...”

“Don’t say anything.”

“So you’re saying it’s not what I’m thinking...?”

She nodded.

Stacy said, “You’re not doing anything?”

She shook her head no. “I just don’t want anything to happen.”

Stacy sighed, rubbed her forehead, leaned on the counter again. “Are you safe?”

“What do you mean safe?”

“Do you feel like you’re in danger?...?”

“With...? Oh, wow. No, nothing like that. I don’t mean like that at all...”

Stacy stared again, bewildered, torn between protocol and friendship. She hated that she put her doctor friend in this position.

“Okay,” Stacy said, “I’m not going to tell you what to do, I just...”

“I don’t know how to explain it, Stacy. I just want it...”

“In case...?”

“I’m telling you it’s nothing.”

“All right,” Stacy said brightly, obviously trying to sound convinced.

Janie reassured her again: “Nothing’s happening, okay?”

Stacy changed the subject. “All right, tell you... You know what...? Let me do it. I’ll push back a patient. It’ll just take us five. Is that okay?”

“Thank you,” she said. *Maybe the fewer people who knew, the better.* Now *she* changed the subject: “So you think the OvoGard is the way to

go?”

She said, “Yeah. It’s the most natural I guess, appeals to hippies like you.”

“I’d like that,” she said. “And I’m not a hippy.”

“You had an IUD before?”

“No.” There were nights she’d cried herself to sleep wishing she had, but, no, she never did.

Stacy patted her knee. “Janie, you stay here, I’ll be back in a minute. Take your pants off for me, okay?”

While Stacy was gone, she removed her jeans and underwear and climbed up on the bed, resting her heels in the swung over stirrups, but covering herself and putting her knees together. Stacy returned quietly with a long plastic-wrap sleeve, put it on the moveable tray and donned latex gloves. Speculum removed from the drawer under the tray, she smiled wanly before inserting it inside her vagina. She swabbed her with alcohol, opened the plastic wrapper and withdrew a long plastic tube with a bundled copper wire tucked in one end like a helix. Without saying anything, she inserted it, probed until it was against her cervix. When it breached, her stomach lurched. It felt like she’d been nipped by a Shih Tzu. “Ow.”

“You okay?”

“Uh-huh.”

“When was your last period?”

“Ten days.”

“This is a good time.”

She exhaled and grimaced.

Stacy said, “He needs to be tested.”

“What?...”

“It’s not my business... but your health is my business—he needs to be tested...”

“For...? Oh. He would’ve been.”

“How do you know?”

“He was tested.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah.”

“He told you that?”

“Evan had to, I know he would have to as well.”

Stacy had been withdrawing the long tube from inside her. She paused, eyes looking blankly at her vulva. *Yeah, I guess I just admitted to the identity of my possible lover—the gorgeous twenty-year-old Italian man you met in my kitchen.*

Stacy withdrew the inserter and discarded it, then worked out the speculum, making her toes curl.

“That’s it,” she sighed.

“Thank you.”

“You probably won’t want sex for a week. You might have cramps, bleeding. If you hurt, call me. You can put a hot water bottle on your tummy, take ibuprofen. But *call* me. *Any* questions, *any* time, day or night, Janie.”

She said, “Stacy, I’m not sleeping with anyone but John. And I’m not going to. I just want this. Do you understand?”

They looked in each other’s eyes. They’d spent months together, pregnant and bitching and hormonal. They’d cried all over each other about the biggest things and the smallest things. When a woman who you’ve poured your guts out to at your most vulnerable time—and you listened when it was their turn—conveyed what she conveyed through their gaze, you didn’t need to say it with words.

Stacy nodded. She drummed her fingers on the inside of her bare thighs, said, “Okay. Now, there’re two strings that hang down from the uterus, I need you to check every other day that they’re still there. We want to make sure the device is still in place. After a week, you can check once just once a month, before you’re ovulating.”

“Strings?”

“Yes. I can trim them. Some men are bothered by them. If his penis is long, I can trim them up higher.”

She said quietly: “You can trim them high.”

Stacy nodded again. “Okay...”

They were silent again. Stacy clipped the strings, tidied up, snapped off the gloves, and Janie got her pants on again.

They stood face to face and awkward. Janie said, “Don’t worry about me.”

Stacy looked a little brighter, said, “I never do. You’re my idol. Strongest woman I know. I wouldn’t have made it adjusting to this rural life without you.”

Now they were both smiling, and Janie hugged her. They held it a long while and when it was time to let go, they smoothed hands over each other's backs.

Stacy said, "We're going to have lunch later this week, promise me."

"I promise. I want that."

One more hug before she gathered her coat and paused at the door. Stacy thanked her for the knitting and she told her it was nothing. Another long uncomfortable moment where both of them wanted to say something but nothing came.

"I'll see you," Janie said.

"I mean it about lunch," Stacy said.

"Call me..."



In the truck, she sat with the heat blasting in her face. Cramps had begun already.

Now she was staring at the blank windows of Stacy's clinic, wondering what her friend was thinking in there. Knew she wouldn't tell anyone, not just because they were friends, but because she was her doctor.

There was no way around what just happened. It had to be done, but it was awful.

She rubbed her cheeks, dug fingertips into her sinuses. She'd have to pick up some ibuprofen on the way home. She sniffed and rubbed her cold nose with her palm, retrieved a tissue from her pocket and blew.

Ah, Stacy, I just led you, my good friend, to believe it was merely temptation and a dreadful ingrained fear of pregnancy that had me acting pragmatic. But, baby, that was just the best face I could put on it so you wouldn't get in my way...

She put the truck in reverse, backed out, wound out of the clinic's parking and headed for Iroquois Falls.

To be continued in Book Three...

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